

OPULENT ARTIST!

Building an Opulent Entertainment Career from Anywhere in the World

Denim Richards

THE OPULENT ARTIST

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By

Denim Richards

This book is dedicated to all of the *Starving Artists* trying to figure out how to feed their hunger in this Global Entertainment Industry. In this book we will not only answer your most important questions such as **"Do I have to live in Hollywood in order to make it in Hollywood?"**

But, I will also be sharing my personal insights of all of my ups and downs in my pursuit to having a thriving and sustainable career. If you are reading this you are not alone in feeling lost and discouraged. Staying up late at night trying to figure out what else do I have to do to break into this industry?

Where do I start?

Do I have to be wealthy to be successful?

How do I find representation when there are no agents or managers in my town, village, or country?

I have had the privilege of traveling all over the world, and everytime I meet a new artist they always feel as though they have the passion for the industry but they don't feel support at home, school, or their country. They are desperate to break into Hollywood and would practically do anything for an opportunity! And while that is noble passion, unchecked it will lead to your poverty. And you will end up in places that do not support the vision you had for yourself.

I am here for you and I want you to reach the highest version of yourself. **Opulent Artist** is not about me! It's about a knowledge transfer. My goal is that you will learn from my mistakes. Those that I made in my younger artistic life, mentally, financially, and emotionally. A journey that will cover everything from sleeping in my car to starring on the global hit show "**Yellowstone**" and everything in between and beyond. Let's starve your frustrations, and feed your success!

Go Opulent Go Global.

Introduction: The Ranch, The Red Carpet, and The Revelation

I was standing in the Montana dirt on the set of *Yellowstone*, the wind blowing through my character's hair, when I had a realization that changed everything. For years, I'd believed what every actor believes: **You have to be in Hollywood to make it in Hollywood.** But here I was, working on one of television's biggest shows, and I was filming in Montana. Not Los Angeles. Not New York. Montana.

The truth hit me like those Rocky Mountain winds: **Hollywood isn't a place anymore. It's an idea.** It's a global marketplace for stories, and today, you can access that marketplace from anywhere in the world.

I've built my career from unexpected places and opportunities, skillfully navigating a diverse landscape of experiences that have profoundly enriched both my life and work. Throughout this journey, I've had the incredible privilege to sit on panels at prestigious events like the World Bank and the Forbes 30 Under 30 summits. During these gatherings, I engaged in meaningful conversations with influential leaders and innovators who are actively shaping our world today. I've also taught masterclasses that have empowered thousands of talented artists across Africa and the Caribbean, passionately sharing valuable knowledge and fostering creativity within these vibrant communities.

Additionally, I've made strategic investments in a wide range of businesses, from the exquisite world of fine wine, where artistry meets commerce, to the dynamic and ever-evolving field of real estate—all while passionately continuing my journey as an actor, embracing every opportunity that comes my way.

This is the modern artist's multifaceted journey, filled with diverse opportunities and unique experiences, and this is your essential guidebook to navigating it successfully.

This book isn't just about acting, it's about building something **opulent**—something rich, valuable, and sustainable—from wherever you are, right now. Whether you're in Lagos, Kingston, Johannesburg, London, Singapore, or a small town in the American Midwest, the rules have changed. The gates are open. You just need to know how to walk through them.

The layout of this book will be different than any other book you have read. This is not a book about me, Denim Richards, this is a war manual...why war? Because that's what life in the world of entertainment is, it's a war, and your objective is to win it, one battle at a time. Together, we will win this fight while offering actionable advice, built on my real world experience and the experiences of 'Generals' (Veteran Artists) within the business of entertainment.

Ready or not...lets go to war!

Chapter 1: Start Where You Are (Your Hometown is Your Hollywood)

"The most powerful location you'll ever film in is your own backyard." - Denim Richards

When I first embarked on this transformative journey of self-discovery and growth, I held the steadfast belief that in order to truly achieve success, I needed to completely abandon everything that was familiar and dear to me—my roots, my connections, and my comforts. I thought that leaving behind my past and everything I cherished was not just essential but perhaps even imperative for my growth and progress. However, I have come to understand over time that this belief was fundamentally flawed and misguided in its essence. Your unique perspective—encompassing not only your distinct accent but also your rich and vibrant culture, along with the diverse and varied experiences you bring to the table—is, in fact, your most significant and invaluable asset.

These elements are not merely aspects of your identity; they play a vital role in shaping your individuality and inner strength. They contribute immensely to who you are, enhancing your ability to connect with others in meaningful ways that foster genuine relationships. Embracing these vital elements of yourself is crucial, as they not only define you but also empower you to forge deeper relationships and foster understanding in an increasingly diverse world. Recognizing the immense value of your background and experiences can be transformative, allowing you to navigate life's challenges with authenticity, resilience, and confidence.

Ultimately, it's through celebrating our unique identities and the richness they bring that we can truly thrive together in harmony and mutual respect. Maybe it's just my opinion, but let's dive into the numbers and see what they have to say. After all, we are always told that as artists we are too "emotional," so instead of using emotion, let's use data, and from there you will decide if you really need to get to Hollywood.

The Data Doesn't Lie:

Approximately 75% of Netflix's total spending in 2023 was allocated to productions that were filmed outside of California, according to the Netflix Investor Report.

'Atlanta, Vancouver, London, and Cape Town have now emerged as significant and influential production hubs in the global market.

"Nollywood" produces a greater number of films each year compared to Hollywood, with over 2,500 films being made in Nigeria versus around 700 films produced in the United States.

So what does this mean?

This means that you... yes, you! From wherever you are reading this war manual, you can make it happen from where you are! Don't get caught in the trap of not getting started because you are waiting for the perfect opportunity or perfect location. Geez, I should have taken my own advice.

The year was 2013, and I was living in North Hollywood with a group of guys who all wanted to live the "Hollywood dream." You had me, the actor; a writer; a director; and a producer all living under one roof. We were going to make it happen; we had talent, time, and opportunities. We would spend countless nights discussing film and TV, what we would do when we got on one of these shows or movies, how we would shoot it, direct it, etc. The nights never ended; we had so many opinions.

Finally, I said, "Look, we seem to have all of the components to shoot something; hell, we even had a camera... so let's do it! Let's go to war."

So that's what we did. We set out on the journey to create a masterpiece, to create the content that Hollywood has been waiting for since its inception. Don't laugh! We are making it happen. I was in charge of locations; it wasn't enough to just be an actor; I needed to get in early and be a part of pre-production!

"What is pre-production again?"

It's the stage in the creative process where you are trying to put all of the ingredients together. Locking in on the script, story, locations, actors, and oh yeah... how much is this going to cost? Wait, what? We have to pay for this as well? I thought our combined passion was enough to get us over the finish line?!

I can hear the denizens of the future yelling, "Your passion is gonna make you poor!" Unfortunately, I didn't know that that denizen would even exist.

Anyways, so there we were, deep into pre-production, finally living out our dreams... playing basketball on the outdoor courts of North Hollywood by day and Madden on Xbox by night!

Wait, what? You mean we actually had to do work? I thought we could just say all of the fancy industry words and then magically things would start to manifest in our favor.

Yeah, unfortunately, the manifestation didn't manifest. Imagine we were still talking about all of the things we were going to do even as we were playing games; our delusion was so strong, or at least I should say mine was. Throughout much of my early artistic life, I thought I could just flip a switch and make things happen. Does any of this sound familiar? My vision was not matching my reality.

What was I to do?

After several months, my frustration grew, not realizing I was part of the problem.

Did we even believe the things we were saying?

Did we believe in each other?

Did we even actually want to be in the entertainment world?

I had more questions than answers. We needed a solid plan, a roadmap, a leader—someone to get us from thoughts to action. Little did I know that leader was never going to come; they were too busy distracting themselves from the realities of the work it requires to be successful. I realized that it didn't matter that I was smack dab in the middle of Hollywood, surrounded by others who claimed to want to do the same things I wanted to do. We had the perfect situation; we were not thousands of miles away or even a continent away.

So, what was the problem?

Why couldn't we create our reality?

If I can't make it here when I'm in the middle of it, what chance does anyone else have that's not here? And I'm talented!!! Lol, yes, these are the thoughts that would always go through my head. I've always been confident; others may even say cocky, but it's not my job to tell you which one it is. I'm digressing.

Mindset, the problem was my mindset. We had all of the components to create, but we didn't, not because it wasn't possible, but because we each individually had our vision of what success looked like.

What did it even matter shooting something in our two-bedroom apartment if it's not on a Hollywood set?

Everything felt small and insignificant. We just wanted to be on the big set, with the big actors, rolling around in big money. Aww, if I could go back and hug that Denim... he was so misguided, and his delusion was misplaced.

Who am I kidding?

He would not have listened; it's hard to hear when you're on a basketball court and playing video games. As I write this now, I wonder what you are not doing because you feel like it's not big enough or 'Hollywood' enough? And this becomes the trap. The trap is you never get started because you already want to get to the end, and the only place where you get to skip all of these steps is in your dreams. But in reality, where you want your dreams to exist, you're going to have to put in more work than you can even imagine. Funny enough, that's actually the best part of the process.

Everything of value started small! The tallest buildings in the world started with a grain of concrete. Your favorite fruit or vegetable started with a seed... Even you! So start where you are, with what you have. It does not mean that you can not dream of being on the big set in Hollywood but maybe that's not where you are right now. Make your Backyard your Hollywood, your bedroom, bathroom, garage, cornerstore, tuckshop, townhall, religious institution, car.. thats your Hollywood, use it over and over again to create your vision, and to hone your craft. Hollywood uses all of the things that I have mentioned as props and sets on all of the programs that you like to watch.

So what does this mean?

It means Hollywood is closer than you think! You just have to be willing to shift your mindset from making it a location that sits in Los Angeles, California to wherever you are right now.

I understand that all of this may seem pretty straightforward at first glance. Haha, just shift your mindset a little, and everything will begin to unfold in ways you might not expect! Interestingly, the most challenging aspect of this journey is actually changing your mindset, especially if you lack a clear roadmap or some sort of guidance to follow. I can relate to this feeling because I didn't have one either, and as a result, I often found myself chasing waterfalls. (If you grew up in the 90s, you'll definitely understand this reference)

For a moment lets shift our focus from the Hollywood thats in Los Angeles, CA to the one that Is in your backyard.

How can you exploit it? Take advantage of it? Mine it?

Let me offer some practical things that i would do if i was where you are, and this can be used from anywhere in the world. Lets call it your Action Plan. The plan were we are no longer focusing on what we dont have but, focusing on what we do have. Nothing is off limits, we are going to war and we can not be afraid of the outcome, and we absolutely can not go to war with fear that something we try may or may not work. In the begining we need to keep it simple, part of the reason that we never get started with anything is because we dont fall in love with the simple things, well together we are going to go thru the bootcamp of the simple things and will come out in love with them.

Your Action Plan:

R&D- Research and Development.

This process is super important and often times we completely over look it because again as I keep saying we overlook the small things so we can get to the big things, but you research whats happening in the area you are in, find a way to plug into it.

It's all about getting into the game. The great thing about this day and age is almost everyone has a super computer in their pocket so you can easily do search and see what the opportunities are. Remember, there is nothing too small in the beginning, we are here to learn and absorb.

Explore the entertainment industry that exists in your country: Each nation has its own unique form of an entertainment industry, which may include theater, radio broadcasts, local television stations, or even diverse digital content platforms. Begin your journey of discovery there.

You want to be an actor and that's your dream and the only industry you see in your area is the local news well guess what? That is a form of acting, you have to get there early, do hair and make-up, memorize opening scripts and even read from a teleprompter which is a unique skillset. Sounds a lot like acting doesn't it?

Now imagine doing that for a period of time and honing your skills then maybe, you take it a step further and find a local theater production, it could be at your religious institution or at your community hall. Imagine audition for a show and getting in, and now you could have to gigs, doing the news by day and theater by night. Look at you, you're booked and busy.

Notice I've said nothing about money or stardom. We are not there yet. We are building and growing, but let's keep it real, if you're working at a news station they are going to pay you something but, that's not the point of our current conversation.

Imagine, all you had to do was ask some questions, and be willing to show up and who knows what could happen. I use the war analogy again.. when you are trying to take a territory nothing can be off limits take everything you see.

Build & Repair: Collaborate (more on this later) with talented local filmmakers to create compelling content.

Once upon a time in Hollywood there was an era where all you needed was a great headshot, your headshot would show off your dynamic personality, and different looks of the roles you might be able to play, the great thing about that was, you were actually able to access audition and even book roles based on how good your headshot was. Well that era ended a long time ago now, you must have a demo reel.

What is a DEMO REEL you may ask?

It's you doing a scene or even multiple scenes that you edit down into a 2 min show reel. This gives the casting director, director, and or producers an opportunity to see what you look like on camera as well seeing if your look matches what they are seeing. This is also gives them an excellent chance to evaluate where you are in your acting capabilities so, its very important that you have a strong demo reel and the great thing about this is, its easy to create.

All you need to do is find a scene from a tv show or movie, find a fellow actor to read lines with you in the scene, and lastly find someone to shoot and edit, now, because of technology you can probably shoot and edit a simple scene, but part of this exercise is collaboration, and that does not happen just sitting by yourself however, if thats the road you need to travel in order to get it done then you do what you must.

Under no circumstances can you skip this part. Why?

Because your demo is your business card; it's your way of showing yourself and those in the entertainment world that you are serious about the commitment.

An agent or manager won't even give you a real chance for an interview without you having a reel. There are artists all over the world who are not waiting around to get cast in some massive production. They are shooting with what they have, and what they have is a desire to constantly hone their craft and become more comfortable in front of the camera.

There is no safer place to practice than in the privacy of your own space, potentially surrounded by others who are all aspiring and practicing together.

Seek & Destroy:

Become the biggest fish in your own pond: Excellence has a way of traveling far and wide. Strive to be so exceptional within your local community that people simply cannot ignore your talent and contributions.

I have traveled around the world. I have spoken and taught masterclasses to thousands of artists from different age ranges, ethnic groups, and financial demographics, and the one thing that always remains constant is their belief that 'I will be a star when I get to Hollywood!'

They truly believe it; they have all of these ideas that they have made up in their heads, thinking that if they can just buy that plane ticket and get to America, then somehow Disney, Netflix, or Paramount will be waiting to pick them up from the airport and drive them straight to set.

Does this sound like you?

Well, it was me as well.

But the reality is, how will you be a star in Hollywood, CA, if no one even knows you in the town, city, village, or country you are currently in?

Again, this becomes another trap; avoid this one at all costs.

Dominate your market and 'Hollywood' will find you. If you are grinding and hustling, always honing your craft, booking jobs, putting yourself on tape, and even posting those videos to social media where people can see that there has been real investment in the quality you are presenting, better opportunities will come. Just be aware that the opportunity may not come wrapped in the package you were expecting.

Remember, we are moving from a dream state of mind to an actionable reality state of mind. Talent will always find talent, so put your head down and fall in love with the work in this process. Look out your window and say to yourself, 'I want to take advantage of every opportunity that's out there!' and mean it, then go do it. Be known for doing great artistic work where you are. Research where the next opportunity may present itself, pursue those opportunities with massive preparation, and then... take it all.

Before Yellowstone, I devoted myself to building a strong and diverse resume by participating in numerous regional theater/Musical productions and even engaging in several student films.

I remember thinking to myself "I am way too good to be doing community theater and I definitely don't want some 18 year old first year university student telling me if I am good enough to be in their production. However, those initial credits not only opened doors but also paved the way for even better opportunities, and enriching experiences throughout my career. Every single step I took along this journey truly mattered and has contributed to shaping the professional I am today and it all started from where I was.

Chapter 2: At The Enemies Gates...The Audition

"I can remember getting rejected systematically by casting directors as a young kid. I felt like the biggest outsider there ever was; that I'd never belong in that club." -Leonardo DiCaprio

At 15 years old, I was sitting in a waiting room in Burbank, California, surrounded by 25 teenagers who all looked vaguely like me. I was much shorter than I am now, had a shaved head, my face was breaking out, and I was sweating like I was going to prison. Anyway, we were all auditioning for the same role—"Best Friend #2" in a network sitcom. I watched as each actor went in, came out five minutes later, and we all tried to read their faces for clues.

Did they get a callback?

Did they make the casting director laugh?

When my turn came, I walked in with sweaty palms, head down, terrified to look anyone in the eyes, and a desperate energy that screamed, "Please like me!"

I stopped in the middle of the room, standing on the X that was placed on the ground.

"Please state your name," the casting director said. Here I am, stuck; I can't even get my name out without stammering.

My heart is racing; I don't even know what my name is, let alone the name of the role. I closed my eyes and did my scene. The casting director gave me a sympathetic smirk.

"Thanks," she said.

Not "Great job." Not "Interesting choice." Just "Thanks." I left knowing I'd failed. And I had.

What was it about the audition process that was so incredibly hellish?

When I was a child, I would run into rooms laughing, energetic, and without a care in the world. Now, as I started to mature, it seemed as though I was unable to walk into a room without feeling completely paralyzed.

"Am I sick?" I pondered. "Had a creature from another planet stolen my confidence?"

That would have been easier than the actual answer. Little did I know I would have no answer for this earth-shattering problem for another 18 years!

So what was it?

What was the problem?

The answer seemed so obvious. It was a lack of preparation!

I was more excited sitting at home imagining all of the opportunities that could come my way, how I could be starring in movies and TV shows alongside all-time great actors, on the cover of magazines, etc., etc. All of that was great at home, but when the opportunity came, I had already made the outcome larger than it needed to be. My thoughts were not pure; I wanted to be a star when in reality I should have just wanted to be a working actor.

Remember, start where you are!

I now understood that if I was going to make a life for myself in this entertainment world, I needed to learn everything there was to know about it: the history, what each title on and off set does, and for me, the most important one... how to **crack the code** and break into Hollywood.

The audition process is very much like a lock that needs to be cracked. The great thing about it is you have the opportunity to crack it! Now, as always, we must reimagine what cracking the audition code means; it simply means putting yourself in the best position to be successful. You can have the best audition of your life and still not book the job! So, booking the job is the end goal, but having a solid and prepared audition is the objective. Let's now dive into some hard truths and something that I have learned to love on this business journey:

The Truth About Auditions That No One Tells You:

Casting directors aren't just looking for what they want. **They're also looking for what they didn't know they wanted until they saw it.**

This was a reality that I had to accept head-on, and I had to learn it the hard way after years and years of stress and rejection. I remember sitting down with legendary actor Obba Babatundé at this popular French restaurant off of Sunset Blvd in Beverly Hills. We would meet often, me having a salad and sparkling water, and he a slice of salmon and a lemonade. He would sit and listen to me cry and complain about how hard this industry is/was (as if he had not been in the industry for 40 years).

But one day, after he finished the last piece of salmon, he simply said, **"Your job is to tell the truth with the lie you've been given; you don't control anything else."**

I was young at the time, and that bar (as the young kids would say) went completely over my head. I'm not lying; I'm acting! What truth are you talking about if I'm lying? You could see the emotional spiral already happening. Little did I know these words would begin to guide me on the path to self-discovery that ultimately helped me crack the code

The Data:

- **The average casting director sees 200-300 actors for a supporting role (Casting Society of America)**
- **They spend 90 seconds to 3 minutes with each actor in initial auditions**
- **73% of casting decisions are influenced by a unique choice or interpretation (Backstage survey)**

Imagine how often we sit around all day thinking about what the casting director, director, or producers are thinking about us and how little we focus on the actual material. Meanwhile, they are seeing hundreds of artists that have composites close to our own, and depending on the level of commitment they observe, may only look at you for 30 seconds (that's shorter than most of us look at a social media post). This happens to the best of us; we want it so badly, but we crave that quick dopamine rush from the sexiest line in entertainment: 'You booked it!' If we want to hear those words early and often, we must change our mindset and dig deep into the details of the craft. Let's take a moment and do a quick check-in test to see which one of these mindsets resonates most with you.

The Three Audition Mindsets (And Why Only One Works):

Mindset 1: The Pleaser

- **Thought:** "I hope they like me"
- **Energy:** Desperate, seeking approval
- **Result:** Forgettable, generic

Mindset 2: The Performer

- **Thought:** "Watch how good I am"
- **Energy:** Showy, demonstrating skill
- **Result:** Technical but lacking heart

Mindset 3: The Partner (This is the one)

- **Thought:** "I am really living the charectors life, and telling the truth with the best lie I have"
- **Energy:** Focused, Confident, collaborative, specific
- **Result:** Memorable, bookable

It wasn't until I stopped trying to give casting directors what I thought they wanted and started bringing them the truth of my interpretation of the character I was reading for that I saw a change. This was helpful because it was no longer about 'booking the job'; it was about advocating for the character that was on the page. When I did that, my audition booking rate skyrocketed.

My unique perspective and love for history, combined with my experiences growing up in blended communities and environments and having specific cultural references, along with my particular humor—these became my assets, not liabilities. Ultimately, I stopped getting nervous when an audition came about; it became an opportunity, and I wanted as many of them as possible. The enemy was being defeated.

The Opulent Artist Audition Framework:

I developed this system for myself after years of trial and error, and I've taught it to thousands of actors worldwide. It works for drama, comedy, film, television, theater—any medium.

Step 1: The Need Hunt

Don't start with the lines. Start with this question: **What does this character need more than oxygen?**

- Is it respect? Love? Safety? Revenge? Freedom?
- Find the core need, and every line becomes a strategy to get it.

Exercise:

Take any scene. Write down what your character needs. Then find three moments in the scene where that need is most desperate.

Step 2: The Obstacle Inventory

What's standing in their way?

- External obstacles: Other people, circumstances, society
- Internal obstacles: Fear, doubt, past trauma
- The best scenes have both

Step 3: The Connection Point

Where does your life intersect with this character's experience?

- You don't need to have been a cowboy to play one
- You need to connect to the universal human experience beneath the specifics

The Audition That Changed Everything

In 2016, I had negative \$600 in my bank account, and the only thing of value I had was this renewed mindset for the craft of Entertainment. I was desperate and focused, which makes for a dangerous combination when it's aimed at the right things. I had no distractions (I couldn't afford any). My back was against the wall, and I needed this focus to pay off. I auditioned for a movie called **Montford: Chickasaw Rancher(Netflix)**.

The character was a man named Jack Brown. You had to be able to sing, be comfortable with firearms, and be able to ride a horse. I remember reading this breakdown and thinking to myself, 'There is no one on the planet more equipped for this role than me.' Again, confidence was never the problem; mindset and focus were. I could not go into this audition the way I had in countless others.

Traditional Approach I Would Have Taken:

- Play him as confident, slick, powerful
- Focus on the "Black Cowboy" stereotype
- Make strong, declarative choices

What I Actually Did:

I remember after digging into the R&D, watching a ridiculous amount of westerns from the Black & white era something dawned on me "The most dangerous people aren't the ones who look tough. They're the ones who are scared but have power anyway."

So, I played Jack as **Useful & Observant**. This period piece was in the 1880s, thus you must acknowledge the pecking order of the color of your skin in relationship to those around you. Jack didn't want to get caught and he knew if he could be useful those around him would advocate and even protect him from getting caught. Every line was armor over fear. Every observant word uttered was a move based in desperation from desperation.

The Result:

I was doing Background(thats where you are the person doing crosses back and forth in a scene, with no lines, name, your atmosphere) Anyways, I was walking back and forth on top of this roof in Downtown LA, thinking to myself I put my most focused, researched, and truthful audition forward and its been over 3 weeks and I have heard nothing.. not even a "Thank you but we are going to pass!".

What was the point?

(No! I did not want to hear thats its about the process, I wanted the job) As I write this it feels so dramatic lol but its true, I am pacing back and forth in this music video, wondering what else does one have to do? I stopped and I looked over the edge of the roof and saw this big city that for the life of me could not figure out how to fit in to it. A few hours later after multiple crosses in front of camera, it was about 5:30pm or so, past the time that any business will be happening so I knew, by 5pm if my phone did not ring there was no job. So, it's 5:30pm my manager calls screaming... **"You booked it!"**.

What the Top Coaches Say:

I've studied and trained with some of the best coaches in the world. Here's their Opuilent wisdom:

From Margie Haber (Margie Haber Acting Studio):

"Living the life, serving the story, finding the good first, and stepping out of your comfort zone, urging actors to ditch impressing for experiencing, focusing on the moment's truth rather than results, and using all their inner pieces to create authentic characters, making performances powerful by being fully present and embracing vulnerability."

From Ivana Chubbuck (Chubbuck Technique):

"The audition isn't about getting the job. It's about solving the problem of the scene in a way that's uniquely yours. Your job is to be so specific in your choices that you become unforgettable."

From Howard Fine (Howard Fine Studio):

"Most actors play the adjective. 'Angry.' 'Sad.' 'Happy.' Great actors play the verb. What are you doing to the other person? Are you destroying them? Elevating them? Protecting them? The verb is always more interesting."

The Opulent Pre-Audition Ritual That Worked for me

I don't believe in superstition, but I believe in preparation. Here's my 60-minute pre-audition ritual:

-60 minutes: Arrive at location (or log in for virtual)

-45 minutes: Review my choices—not my lines. Remind myself of my character's needs and truth.

-30 minutes: Physical warm-up. Not yoga—specific character physicality. If my character is nervous, I might jiggle my leg. If confident, I'll practice standing with weight evenly distributed. This also helps get the "Nervous energy out".

-15 minutes: Vocal warm-up. Tongue twisters, but also practicing the character's rhythm of speech.

-5 minutes: Quiet moment. I say this to myself: "I'm here to tell the truth".

-1 minute: One deep breath, Kill, seek, and destroy.

For Self-Tapes: The ritual is similar but includes tech check 30 minutes before. (More on this in the next chapter)

Handling Different Audition Types:

Commercial Auditions (30 seconds to make an impression):

- **Key:** Energy, authenticity, focus.
- **Trap:** Being too "actor-y"
- **My Secret:** Just be a person. Authentic, genuine.

Theater Auditions (They want to see your range):

- **Key:** Bold choices, vocal control, using the stage as a character.
- **Trap:** Playing to the back row in a small room
- **My Secret:** I find one person in the audience (or imagine one for selftapes) and speak directly to them.

Film/TV Auditions (Intimacy matters):

- **Key:** Listening and reacting
- **Trap:** Over-preparing your performance. Now, you're not listening, thus your reactions are not authentic.
- **My Secret:** I prepare my choices but leave room to discover in the moment. The best film acting happens between the lines. Just like life it's what you don't say that has the most impact, but can be captured with the eyes.

The Post-Audition Protocol:

What you do after matters almost as much as what you do during. Remember, we need to lean into the data so, the best way to do that is to track the what went **right & wrong** of everything leading up to the audition and the audition itself.

Immediately After:

- Note what felt good and what didn't (for learning, data, not judgment)
- Thank everyone by name if possible
- Leave the character in the room

The 24-Hour Rule:

For 24 hours after an audition, I forbid myself from:

- Obsessively checking my phone for calls or emails
- Replaying everything I did wrong
- Comparing myself to other actors I saw or that I think are also up for the role

Instead, I:

- Do something completely unrelated to acting
- Celebrate that I got to do what I love
- Move on mentally to the next thing

Why This is Important: Casting directors can smell desperation. When you audition and forget, you carry no energy of neediness into the next opportunity. You must become an emotional machine with access to all feelings.

Audition Statistics You Should Know:

1. **Booking Rate:** The average working actor books **1 out of every 20-30 auditions** (SAG-AFTRA data)
2. **Callback Rate:** Getting a callback happens **about 10% of the time** for union actors
3. **Director Sessions:** If you get to the director level, your chances improve to **1 in 4 or 5**
4. **Testing/Network Level:** At this stage, it's often **down to 2-3 actors**

What This Means for You:

Rejection isn't personal. It's mathematical. If you're booking 1 in 20, that means 19 "nos" for every "yes." The actors who succeed aren't the ones who never get rejected. They're the ones who keep going after rejection. 10k no's is a real thing. If you can accept it now the better prepared you will be, and you can start to refrain your mindset. **This is a war not a battle.**

More auditions lead to more bookings, even if the percentage stays similar. This is why I say to just keep putting yourself out there, you can not have a mentality that you are "too good" for something when you're in the phase of getting your numbers up. Go after every opportunity.

The Opulent Action Plan:

This Week:

1. Take one scene from a movie or show and apply the **Opulent** Framework to it
2. Record yourself doing it two ways: one "safe" choice, one "bold" choice
3. Show both to a trusted friend and ask which is more compelling

This Month:

1. Create an audition tracker (Google Sheets is fine)
2. For each audition, note: The choice you made, what you learned, how you felt
3. After 5 auditions, look for patterns

Ongoing:

1. **Monthly:** Watch one audition scene breakdown on YouTube (Actors Access has great ones)
2. **Quarterly:** Take an audition technique class, even if online
3. **Annually:** Review your audition tracker and adjust your approach based on what's working.

Data is King.

Every audition is an opportunity to tell the truth. It's about numbers. Every "no" is data. Every room you walk into (or log into) is an opportunity to share your unique perspective.

The Mindset Shift:

Stop thinking "I hope they like me." Start thinking "How can I tell the truth and nothing but the truth."

Next Chapter Preview:

In Chapter 3, we dive deep into the tool that has democratized our industry: the **Self-Tape**. I'll share exactly how I went from hating self-tapes to respecting them, including my equipment setup, technical tips, and psychological strategies for delivering your best performance to a camera instead of a person.

Chapter 3: The Self-Tape Superpower

Confession:

I hated self-tapes. Absolutely hated them. I'm someone who wanted to win the room. I connect with people. How could I do that through a camera? Since this is a confession I was also super nervous about doing self-tapes. Now, I actually have to look at myself before submitting? What if I look crazy? And who am I supposed to be reading with when I don't live in Los Angeles, New York ect. A family member? That always goes over well "Hey I know you're in the middle of watching a rerun but can you help me record myself?" Now you're inviting people that dont know anything about auditioning to have an opinion on your performance lol "Can you be a little more like Denzel in Training Day? I loved that movie!" You get the picture.

For a while, I was able to get away with it. In full disclosure, I will admit that there were handfuls of auditions that I did not record for because, well, self-tape (it's not a good look, and it's a great way to lose your agent and manager if you have them). I wanted the audition room to be my oyster. Imagine, after years of being terrified to go into an audition room, now that's all I want to do. SMH, moving the goalposts...

Then COVID hit, and everything changed. You remember, everything stopped and even shut down, especially the entertainment industry. When things finally started to relax, little did I know the era of walking into a room on a consistent basis was gone. I went from 'No, I don't feel like doing a self-tape' to 'I'll never work again if I don't figure out a way to love self-taping.'

This was one of the many times in my career where I needed to embrace the pivot. Moving off of old ideas and hopes, and embracing the new. Adapt or get left behind.

The Stat That Changed Everything:

- **Pre-2020:** 30% of auditions were self-tapes
- **Post-2022:** 85% of first-round auditions are now self-tapes (Casting Society of America)

These stats blew me away because I know they are accurate, I was/am living in the experience, and once I accepted this, I had to make drastic changes to my mindset. I have such a high opinion of myself but, again the question arose.

"Am I willing to do the work?".

So, I'm back on the basketball court, now before you roll your eyes and call me names...this time the court I was on was in Montana and I was playing on one of my off days on Yellowstone so lol. This was a little bit of a different experience from the time I was in North Hollywood playing on the outside courts (We did win a lot of games though). Anyways, I am getting my shots and my heart is pounding, sweat dripping all over the court, and now I'm having to be cautious of where I am stepping, the last thing I need is to injure myself from my own sweat.

Then I stopped and like a ton of bricks I said out loud "what am I doing?".

Everyday I come to this court to play, whether I have to wake up early before I head to set, or after I am wrapped, and half the day on the weekends, hell, I was even traveling an hour away to play pickup games. But why was I not willing to do the same thing for my craft? You know the thing that is actually making me money, the reason why I am able to afford a gym membership!

What am I afraid of?

Yes I'm on Yellowstone, but as I was told a thousand times, eventually this will end, and when it does what would I have? I'm getting self tape opportunities but I'm not locking in and really focusing in the same way I am focusing on this court.

Now, I'm thinking, this amazing opportunity that has presented itself, I can be on show, and in my downtime be practicing and audition/read for other projects and I don't have to be in LA to do it? So, financially it's a much cheaper expense and you get to shoot your self tape as many times as your heart desires. I don't have to get it right the first time, all of a sudden the self tape enemy became a long lost friend I was always looking for.

I just couldn't see it because I had a vision of the way things needed to look, but the entertainment industry was telling me, it looks a lot like self tapes.

The Revolutionary Truth:

Self-taping is the great democratizer. It means:

- A casting director in London can discover you in Botswana
- You can audition for 5 projects in different countries in one week

Geography is no longer a barrier to opportunity

This truth is something that you can and should take advantage of. The barrier to entry had suddenly been stripped away, and now you didn't have to stress about how to get somewhere for an audition or not being able to audition for a role because you don't live in the area. You can do it from wherever you are, your location did not matter. This is something that would never have been possible 10 years ago, so you are in the perfect position to exploit this opportunity, and that is exactly what it is.

After a few hours of beating myself up for not coming to this revelation sooner, I adopted the better late than never mindset and said, "Let's get serious."

I don't want to just hold my phone up and have it propped up on a bookshelf or on Jenga pieces (although if that's what you have, no excuses—make it work). But the reality is, because you can now self-tape from anywhere, the entertainment space has become even more competitive, and the quality of your self-tape is going to matter almost as much as the audition itself; in fact, it is part of the audition.

If you're going to join the war, join the war to win and with all of your arsenal.

Let's go get the bullets.

My Self-Tape Setup (That Fits in a Backpack):

- Smartphone with 4K capability (\$800)
- (\$0) If you already have one
- Basic ring light (\$50)
- Lavalier microphone (\$100)
- Plain background (\$20 for fabric)

Total: Under \$1,000 for global access

The Mindset Shift:

Your phone isn't a barrier—it's your passport. That little camera is your ticket to any casting office in the world. You went from thinking "locally" to the opportunity to be "Global" and you didn't even have to leave your bedroom.

Chapter 4: Hollywood is an IDEA, Not a Location

Let me take you back to the year 1910, a truly pivotal moment in the expansive history of cinema. During this fascinating period, the film industry was primarily concentrated in the bustling urban centers of New York and New Jersey, where the hustle and bustle of city life provided a unique backdrop for early filmmakers. However, a remarkable trend began to emerge as filmmakers started to migrate westward to California, drawn irresistibly by the abundant sunshine—this is no exaggeration; they genuinely needed the natural light for their productions, which was absolutely crucial for the quality and visual appeal of their work. This significant shift in location meant that Hollywood transformed into a physical destination that everyone in the film industry felt an irresistible urge to be a part of, as if it were a magnet attracting talent and innovation. This marked the beginning of Hollywood's legendary status in the annals of cinema history, setting the stage for its future as the epicenter of filmmaking, where dreams and stories would come to life in ways previously unimagined.

In any business that you enter into, if you are serious about making a true mark in it, you must understand the company's history, who the players are, and how the system runs; otherwise, you're doing nothing but gambling. Learning the history will not only give you a much larger appreciation for the business, but if you follow it correctly, you can start to track the trends. As an artist, you are a small business with the potential to become a big business, so you should absolutely study trends. That way, you can anticipate and be ahead of the curve when opportunities present themselves. This is one of the many ways that you will separate yourself from the pack and add value to any room you walk into.

The Timeline of Change:

- **1910-2000:** "Go West, young artist" was the rule and there no getting around it.
- **2000-2010:** Productions began exploring Canada for tax incentives
- **2010-2020:** Georgia, Louisiana, and New Mexico became "Y'allywood"
- **2020-Present:** Global decentralization

As you can clearly see in the beginning everything moved relatively slowly, infrastructure was being built. Unions formed, Laws of the entertainment world were being constructed, It truly was the wild west. But, you could make the argument that once everything fell into place it was a little more predictable, meaning, you knew where and what you needed to land an opportunity.

But then, all of sudden, with tech advancing, so did the industry and as other countries wanted to get involved in Hollywood machine, it felt like over night things changed. Now, every ten years, give or take there is a major shift. Your job is to be ready for the opportunities today, tomorrow and ten years from now. Sounds exhausting? Yeah well, no one ever said that this industry was easy.

Today's Reality:

- The **#1 filming location** in the world isn't Los Angeles—it's **Atlanta, Georgia**(At the time of writing this)
- **The UK** offers 25-30% tax rebates, attracting billions in production
- **South Africa** has become the go-to for "anywhere in the world" looks
- **New Zealand** built an entire economy around film production

Take a Netflix for an example, they operate in 192 countries and produce content in numerous languages, and they are constantly expanding. It seems like almost everyone in entertainment watched "Squid Games", which was not a "Hollywood" production, but a South Korean production. South Korea doubled down on their culture, language and location and look what happened... Hollywood came to them.

The British Film Institute estimates that there are over 400 productions that shoot in the UK annually. As you can see, their incentives are attracting productions from all over the world and the number is only growing. Marvel studios even left the US (Atlanta) to start shooting their content in the UK, that's tens of thousands of jobs lost to the US that will now become available to the UK, going into the future.

I am now going to ask you the question that I ask every actor I come across who say they want to be in the entertainment industry, and specifically at the end of my Master Classes (Business of Entertainment). When this question is asked everyone usually pauses and looks around to see what everyone around them is thinking.

It goes like this "Raise your hand if you want to be in the entertainment industry?" Everyone emphatically raised their hands. "Raise your hand if you want to make money in the entertainment industry?" People raise both hands, some even stand up. Then the hammer drops. "Who wants to be in the entertainment Industry if it's not in Hollywood?" Ah now, there's the fine print.

Would you consider yourself a successful artist if you never stepped foot on a Hollywood production shot in Los Angeles? This is something that you as the artist need to think and be honest about. This question forces you to consider are you looking to be a working actor? Or are you just saying that you want to be an actor because you want "stardom" that you believe can only come from Hollywood? My advice is fall in love with craft and strive to be a successful working actor no matter where in the world your craft takes you.

The Mental Exercise:

When you say "I want to be in Hollywood," what do you actually mean? Do you mean:

- You want to be in successful films and TV shows? (You can do that from anywhere)
- You want to work with great directors? (They work globally)
- You want financial success and creative fulfillment? (Geography independent)

Hollywood is now a global network. Your Wi-Fi connection is your membership card.

Chapter 5: Finding Your Agent Locally & Globally

I'll never forget the first time I signed with an agent in a country I didn't live in. I was nervous. Would they remember me? Would they prioritize their local clients? This is something that I didn't even know was possible...after all they don't teach this in the Universities (Not like I went to one) and it's rare if ever you take a class where they bring this up. The reality of it is, I was always thinking locally not globally. The assumption was if I just got one agent then I did it, right?

You did something. And I am not going to pretend like it's not a major feat but, even agents today are looking for clients that have a global appeal because they themselves are running businesses, and those businesses need to expand. So if you come with that value proposition that becomes highly attractive. Are you beginning to feel a little better about yourself and where you are in the world? You should.

The fact of the matter is that for decades agents in the USA and the UK have been signing artists from all over the world, and those artists are working in countries where they don't reside. You see them every day when you turn on your TV; you may just not realize it because those actors work on their craft 24/7 and are able to do the accents that fit the countries they are working in, allowing them to participate in productions that are realistic.

This is something I am still working on. Imagine you become established in the country where you are living, using the big fish model. Then you expand into another country using your agents. Now, production has an opportunity for their movie or TV show to do even better in the country you come from because you are in the show. You bring the homegrown audience, and that adds extreme value. More on this in an upcoming chapter.

Let's get into the absolute non-negotiables that you must have to land an interview with an agency whether that's locally or globally, these rules are universal and there is no way you're going to get around them. Remember, no one is going to invest in you, if you haven't been seen to have been investing in yourself. So don't take this lightly.

The Truth:

Good agents want one thing—**talent that makes them money**. They don't care where you live if you can deliver.

What You Need Before You Submit:

1. **Professional Headshots** (Not selfies)
2. **A Compelling Reel** (3 minutes max of your best work)
3. **A Clean, Professional Website** (Your digital business card)
4. **IMDb Credits** (Even if they're local—credits are credits)
5. **Training Listed** (Who you've studied with matters)

In 2012, I signed with a manager. How in the world did I land a manager without having all of the proper tools for my journey? We will talk about that in the next chapter.

Nonetheless, she said, 'Denim, we need photos in order to get you an agent.' She wasn't asking me for credits—I had some local projects—or even a reel; she just wanted headshots that could show the agents what roles I could potentially audition for. There was only one problem: I had no money! Of course, I didn't tell her that.

I just said, 'Okay, I'll get it done.'

I scrambled looking online for the cheapest person who could shoot headshots, and then I thought I would just ask my family for some money, hoping they would lend it to me, knowing that I was moving in the right direction.

So I booked the shoot and brought the clothes that I had in my closet. I was going to get 3 looks (changes) for about \$75. Not bad, right? Now, if you're in another country, you might say it's crazy, but this is comparable to the country you are residing in. Anyway, I showed up with my clothes (most of them wrinkled, another mistake). We did the shoot, and at the end, I had never felt better. I was smiling in all the shots and trying to give a serious vibe in another look. I sent them to her, and she said, 'Okay, well, it's something. I'll see what I can do.' Well, I landed an agency meeting! 'I did it!' I am finally on my way to being the actor I always knew I wanted to be.

Only one problem: the agent didn't like the photos.

"What?!"

He said they did not match the personality I had when I walked into the meeting.

He was happy to sign me, but there had to be more appropriate photos. 'Now what?'

I already didn't have money like that, and now I have to go back and borrow more to do it again? So that's what I did. I went back with the same photographer and some of the same clothes (still wrinkled by the way...when will i learn?) and of course the photographer was happy because he was going to make more money.

So we do the shoot and all I could think about was "make sure i am giving my personality" wait..what was my "personality again?"

I never even thought about it. I thought I should just show up, smile and be serious. But the reality is, its much deeper, little did I know but, as always I was going to learn the hard way! We wrapped the photo shoot and I was like alright. I had followed the agent's directions, lets sign contracts and get to the audition!

Yeah, he didn't like them.

"Again?!"

What is happening?

In my mind, this agent has to be a fraud because you're not going to tell me that I've take multiple headshots and none of them are good enough to get signed.

Guess what happened?

The agency dropped me because in their mind I wasn't serious about the craft. And they are running a business, not a tutoring center on how to take the proper headshots. What a gut punch. If he had only known that I had to borrow money to get these done he would have seen it another way..that was the lie I told myself.

My manager called me and says, "Look doll, if you can't get me proper headshots then there is nothing that I can do for you, and I need to move on to other clients that can do this ever so simple task!"

Yeah, easy for you to say, your other clients must have money. The reality was they were both right! They don't want to hear your story on why you're not able to deliver, that's not their job, that's yours. You better go out there and figure it out. So after much complaining, I decided to go and take some odd jobs, I became a nanny, so that I could save up some money to do this right.

After several months and begging my manager not to drop me, I promised the next headshots I was going to take would deliver the goods. She was patient, more than she should have been and to be honest I would have dropped me but, she saw something that kept her on my wild ride. Needless to say, I saved up enough, and found the top photographers in my area, booked an appointment, bought new clothes, all ironed. There's something about having to pay for things yourself that forces you to lock in. And I took the best headshots to that date.

My manager called me and said "Wow! Now this, I can work with".

What transpired was an agent signing, and shortly thereafter, one of my first national commercials was booked mainly from my headshot. So I say all of that to say, whatever you do, do not try to save money on your headshot. It's the first thing agents, managers, and casting directors look at before you enter a room, and you better look like the photos that are presented.

What's the Reel?

Now that we got that headshot out of the way, let's talk briefly about the reel. If your headshot is the face of your business, then your reel is your calling card. This shows what your acting capabilities are, and you better put your best foot forward. Because if you are going to land that agent, they are going to demand it; otherwise, they won't even consider looking at you, no matter how good you are. Now, you might be saying, didn't you just get away with it? Yes, in 2012, I booked a commercial, not a TV show or movie. The great thing for you is that back then, phones were not shooting in high definition and definitely not in 4K, so you have a solid advantage that I didn't have then.

When doing your reel, don't overcomplicate it and try to shoot a movie, because an agent is not going to sit down and watch 10 minutes of anything, let alone a full-length feature. Your reel should ideally be no longer than 3 minutes, and it's just one scene if you're starting out with no other projects filmed under your belt.

If you do have several filmed, high-quality projects, pick the best moments and cut them together to land on that 3-minute mark. You can easily go online and type in scripts from movies or TV shows, NOT a play, and look for something that is appropriate for your age range and acting abilities. This is not your time to pick from your favorite movie or show and try to put on your award-winning copy of what you liked; this is the time to show what you look like in front of a camera and your ability to be grounded and believable. Have fun, because remember, just like the self-tape, you can do it over and over again until you get it right.

Make sure to shoot your scene with a reader (someone to read the other lines of the character). So yes, I am saying I would respectfully suggest that you don't do a monologue. When you're doing your R&D, look at how many TV shows and movies actually have monologues; very few. Your reel is your opportunity to showcase your timing in a scene, your ability to react to the words of the other character, and to make strong choices. Ensure that the coverage (the camera is mostly on you) highlights you.

Do I really need a website?

The short answer is no! A website now is also your social media; you should be using all of the social tools to show the type of artist you are. It's free and easy, so make sure that your socials are clean and represent how you want people in the business world to see you, because trust me, they are looking and making decisions based on what they are seeing.

The website is a way to aggregate all of your work into one area that you solely own, which can eventually go into your Electronic Press Kit (EPK).

This is great because it elevates you to a level of professionalism that screams, "I take this industry seriously." Is it a deal breaker for landing an agent?

No. But can it increase your odds? Absolutely! Now, an agent doesn't have to go to different platforms to see your work. You can send one link, and everything you've done is there. Remember, and it's hard, agents are people too, so they get bored, distracted, and have time constraints. The easier you make it for them to access your information without them having to do a lot of searching and digging, the better.

Do I have Credit?

Globally, the industry uses IMDb (Internet Movie Database). You can go there and type in movies, TV shows, etc., and see the actors that were part of the projects. Then you can click on the artist and see all of their credits from projects they have worked on, past and present. IMDb is what everyone uses to see how legitimate an artist or production is, as you don't just get to create a profile and make things up; everything is verified through them. Now, if you're doing local projects, don't get discouraged; this is something that you are working towards. Remember, start where you are and grow.

Training:

This is probably the most straightforward. Agents want to know where you learned your craft. Many people have only trained in school, their university, etc., but in order for your training to stand out, it helps if you can say that you trained with a well-known and respected company and/or teacher. Again, it's not a deal breaker; however, agents might not feel as comfortable submitting you for roles and projects if they feel as though you haven't been trained in a way that prepares you to handle the expectations of the industry. Even in other businesses, they will put you through some kind of company training to ensure that you are able to meet company standards; this is no different in entertainment.

Do a search in your area and find the top acting coaches or acting classes, and inquire about how you can audit (sit in on a class or session for free) to see if it's a good fit for you. There are some actors who have never taken an acting class outside of the school they attended, and that's great for them.

But is it great for you?

You have to be honest about the artist you currently are and decide if you think you know enough naturally to compete at the highest levels of this industry. Many, if not most, of your award-winning actors still to this today, they have private coaches to help them figure out a role and ground themselves. I would follow that same roadmap and find a class.

At the bare minimum, you get to surround yourself with like-minded artists, explore different ranges in your craft without the pressure of having to "book" a job, and receive feedback. Not to mention, you may even find great scene partners to shoot your reel. And lastly, you never know what the people in the room are working on; they might have connections to opportunities that you can't find online.

After all of this.. lets go get you an agent!

The Submission Strategy:

1. **Research agents who represent your "type":** Look at actors who look like you or play roles you could play. See who represents them.
2. **Personalize every email:** "I saw you represent [Actor's Name], and I believe I could be a great addition for similar roles because..."
3. **Follow up once:** After 2 weeks, a polite follow-up shows professionalism.

If you want an agent to take you seriously, take yourself seriously. Remember "No one is going to invest in you if you haven't shown that you've invested in yourself!"

Chapter 6: What Is There to Manage?

I always feel as though this is a hot topic of conversation but, it's an important one to get right, especially early on in your artistic journey. Now, everyone that is in the industry will have their unique perspective so let me offer mine.

Early on in my journey, I was obsessed with wanting to look the part! I wanted the agent, manager, lawyer, publicist, assistant, etc. The funny thing is, I really didn't know what any of the roles actually did. Like, how do they help you in your career? But I didn't care to know any of that because all of the 'celebrities' had them, and thus I wanted them. There are so many problems with this thought process, and it all goes back to the R&D. We want things that we don't understand, and then we end up in situations business blind. As you are on this journey, you must be intentional with everything you do. It's easy to be taken advantage of, and many times our lack of studying leads us directly into the belly of the beast.

The Question I Get Asked Most:

"When do I need a manager?"

The Answer:

"When you have something to manage."

This answer seems so simple, but you would be surprised how many artists in their journey think that in order for them to be taken seriously, they have to have a manager. Does this sound like you?

Remember, I did the same thing, and it wasn't until I was much older that I realized having a manager with nothing to manage is as helpful as having a life jacket in the desert; it makes no sense.

What made it worse was that I didn't even know what the major difference was between a manager and an agent.

In my mind, the manager is the one who talks to your agent on your behalf, and then they help book your travel and accommodations and ask you questions like, 'What snacks do you want in your trailer?' (Oh Denim!)

Although, those things can and do happen, that is not the primary objective for a manager. So, what is the difference between an agent and a manager?

What a Manager Actually Does (vs. an Agent):

- **Agent:** Gets you auditions, (can even, but not always recommended, negotiates contracts)
- **Manager:** Develops your career strategy, builds your brand, creates opportunities

Let's keep it super simple, shall we?

The reason is, in this ever evolving industry, its easy for the Agent and Manager rolls to become blurred and as an artist, you have to ensure that you understand what everyones role is, including yours!

Now, I know what your thinking..."Denim, didn't you say in the last chapter that you got a manager before an agent? And now your writing an entire chapter to tell us not to do the same?"

The short answer is no!

You can do whatever you feel is best for you and your career but, you have to have some type of forward vision.

Let me explain.

In 2012, I belonged to this men's group for, you guessed it, men who are in and/or are pursuing the entertainment industry. We would meet monthly to discuss what we were learning, and there would be special guests who would come in to impart knowledge and wisdom to us. I was already craving the opportunity to get deeper entrenched in the business, but like many of us, I had no idea where to start, and this felt like an opportunity.

Anyway, one day they asked a group of us to go down to a local radio station to discuss some of the projects we were working on, as it would be broadcast to the community. I guess it was a way of saying that things were happening and locals should watch out because people who live right next to them are going to be big. I had no idea why I was invited, as I didn't have anything going on except my excitement for the industry and this idea for a movie that I wanted to do. But I had no script, deck, budget, access—you name it, I didn't have it.

So, there I was sitting in the radio lobby, everyone all dressed up. Why? I don't know; it's radio, but I guess it's dress to impress. I think I even bought a black hat so I could feel more official, and my shirt wasn't as wrinkled (progress, am I right?).

I'm sitting there thinking to myself, "What do I say when they ask me a question?"

It's not like I was trained, but who cares. In we went; there had to be at least eight of us in the room. I'm confident now that there isn't much of a chance that I will be asked any questions; I am the furthest person away from the DJ, and there were people in there who were actually doing something in the industry. The show starts, and the DJ goes around the table asking everyone what their name is. I immediately have flashbacks to when I was younger, walking into an audition room and not being able to say my name. Luckily, this time I managed.

I said, "Denim Richards."

The DJ, who was female, and the rest of the ladies were like, "Oooooo, his voice is so deep; we weren't expecting that looking at you!"

In that moment, I was like, "Is this a compliment or an insult?"

Looking back, it was probably both; such is life. So I say one or two things about myself: I am an actor, and I belong to this men's group, and then they moved on to the next person.

The show ends and a woman walks up to me and says, "Hey, you really do have a nice radio voice!"

She introduces herself and says she has just moved to the city from another state, and it would be great if we could talk further.

I was super excited; I showed up to this opportunity with no real expectations, and the thing I showed up for has potentially landed me a meeting with someone in the entertainment business (just show up).

Fast-forwarding, we met up a lunch, and I proceeded to tell her all about this grand vision I had for my career. I mentioned that I had done theater, musical theater, trained as an opera singer, and now I was trying to write this period piece movie. She informed me that she had moved out to LA to start her own management company and had spoken to one or two people to potentially be her first clients.

After several meetings, that's when we decided to partner, as we were both growing, learning, but had a great hunger for the industry. We went on a long journey together, but at the start, we did run into the problem of, 'now we have to get you an agent, photos, reel, etc.' Keep in mind, your agent and your manager don't make money unless you do, and many are not going to have a lot of patience to wait around if you already don't have some momentum behind you.

We were together for 12 years, and we accomplished a lot. But do I think that I would have been signed to her management company if she had not just started? No, I don't. And how do I know this? Because I met many managers in the process, and all of them heard my voice. I even shared my vision for myself with them, but that never led to a signing.

Looking back, I don't regret a moment. I do, however, believe I had made things harder than they needed to be. I didn't put myself or my manager in the best position to be successful. As I mentioned in the last chapter, I didn't even have proper photos that were up to date. No one in the industry was checking for me; I wasn't even in a local theater show. The least I could have done was create some momentum for myself to make everyone's job easier.

Now, in this global entertainment space, it is more important than ever to create the waves yourself. Don't stand on the beach and glare longingly into the ocean, waiting for the perfect wave (opportunity); it might not ever come, so don't bank on it. Create it.

When am I Manager Ready?:

Some things to consider.

1. You're booking work consistently and your looking to scale your buisness
2. You have multiple income streams (acting, teaching, creating) and trying to figure out how to balance all of them
3. You need someone to help you say "no" to the things that are not aligned to the company's (You) vision.
4. You have to have a vision bigger than the next audition

"Ask not what your country can do for you but, what can you do for your country!"- **John F. Kennedy** (JFK)

Likewise, "I ask not what your manager can do for you but, what can you do for yourself that your manager can add on to?"

One of the major traps that many artists fall into on their artistic journey is the thought that once they have a manager or even an agent, their job is done! Many think that this is the end goal: to get signed and that it's up to everyone else but them. This is a myth!

There have been many artists who have been led astray and even dropped from their representation because they became comfortable and complacent.

When you finally get an opportunity to have a manager, your job is just beginning. You are still responsible for creating opportunities for yourself and growing your craft. Please don't rest on one checkpoint when there is an entire race to run.

So, before you go hunting for a manager, ask yourself the important question: 'What do I have to manage?'

What You Bring to a Manager:

- A clear vision for your career(although it can and will change)
- Professionalism (you show up on time, prepared, and ready to take advantage of opportunities)
- **Your own hustle** (they open doors, but you walk through them)

Your Manager SHOULD be your asset:

Vision, direction, connection, and execution. These are some of the core assets that your manager should bring to your table. They are the fuel that ignites your fire! To get the most out of them and yourself, make sure you are honest about where you are on your path and what you still need to work on. Don't be like me, desperate for the "celebrity look" when I haven't even booked a role yet. Take the time to identify your assets (the things that make you special) and your liabilities (your weaknesses that could cost you opportunities).

Lean into your assets, and on the side, work on tightening up your liabilities.

I wouldn't be able to finish this chapter if I didn't mention something that I am noticing more and more, especially in emerging entertainment markets. Again, we must be unapologetic and tell the truth! More and more, I am seeing artists who allow individuals with no industry experience to become their managers. Why is it happening? Because, in certain places, specifically a continent like Africa, the entertainment industry is still relatively new, especially when you look at it from a sustainability and profit-making point of view.

There are not many talent agencies or management companies, so many artists feel the need to just dance with who they came to the dance with.

So, as much as I understand this, I would advise heavily against it. This industry is not about making sure you have familiar faces around you 24/7; this industry is a business, and you must treat it as such! You would never board an airplane and fly across the world with a pilot who has never flown before! So why leave the future of your career in the hands of someone who has no experience?

Rather, it would be better for you to sit and learn as much of the ins and outs so that when an opportunity for a manager presents itself, you know exactly what to ask and what to expect.

Somewhere, there is an artist signed to a close loved one, frustrated that their career is not going to the next level even though they have a strong vision for themselves, but because they refuse to treat this industry like the business it is, they are losing out on potential opportunities, and the unfortunate part is they didn't even know that there were opportunities to be missed.

You are the foundation of your entire career; everyone else is there to ensure that the foundation can be built upon and that the structures remain solid. In this next chapter, we will discuss how you can build your brand from anywhere in the world.

Chapter 7: The Brand Called "You"

Let's take a moment to embrace some discomfort: Whether you choose to acknowledge it or not, you are running a business, and every business demands a strong brand. Coming to terms with this fact was one of the most difficult realizations I had to face. Picture yourself putting in countless hours of effort just to land an audition, competing for a role that could attract hundreds or even thousands of equally talented individuals all seeking the same opportunity.

After enduring all that hard work and finally securing the role, someone casually asks you, "So, what's your brand?"

You might find yourself stumbling over your words, responding with, "Um, my brand is that I'm an actor, obviously!"

But here comes the reality check: in the current landscape, as I have stressed repeatedly throughout this book, you must embody more than just a single identity. This doesn't imply that you should fall into the trap of attempting to be everything all at once; instead, it's crucial to have a distinct vision for your future and to be very intentional in articulating what your brand genuinely represents. It's vital to grasp that your brand is not merely a label; it is an essential aspect of your identity as both a performer and a business professional, shaping how others perceive you in a crowded marketplace.

This reality really struck home on a particular podcast that we were recording. Yes! I said podcast. Can you guess the name? If you said "**The Unapologetic Podcast**" on Patreon, then you would be correct (not so shameless plug). Anyway, we were discussing how easy it is to get stuck as an artist when you feel as though you are always straddling a line between what I call being a "Holistic Thespian" and the "Artisticpreneur."

The Holistic Thespian is the artist who believes the only thing you should focus on is your craft; social media is a distraction, networking is a waste of time, and if you just do the work, then your craft will speak for itself. Now, there is much in this ideology that is true: your work as an artist is the most important aspect, as it is the foundation of your brand. If the foundation is shaky, then the brand will fail. But two things can be true, and in this new age of a global entertainment industry, you must accept this as an artist.

Now, the Artisticpreneur understands that the foundation is the craft, and that foundation should be reinforced as much as possible. However, they also understand that it won't matter how solid the foundation is if no one knows it exists. (More on the Artisticpreneur in a moment.) You must find a way to brand and market yourself, and not for the reasons you may think! It shouldn't be so you'll become a star, and it definitely shouldn't be because you think a casting director will hire you because they saw you on social media. By now, if you've made it to this chapter, then you should be asking yourself the important question: What does the data say about this? Thank you for asking; let's check it out!

The Data:

- **73% of casting directors** check social media before bringing someone in (Backstage Survey)

But only 12% said a large following influences casting

What they're looking for: Professionalism, personality, and whether you'll be difficult to work with

Hopefully, the more you engage with the data, the more it aids you in making stronger and more foundational decisions. As you read that 73% of casting directors check your social media presence before considering you for an audition, remember that this doesn't guarantee you the job. However, it does indicate that having a strong and positive presence on social media could create an opportunity for you to get in the room.

Once you're there, that's where your craft truly takes over and shines. For many, it might be easier to view social media as a tool to create value, which is essentially your branding. Over time, this branding can lead to opportunities that might not have been available otherwise. Once you gain access to these opportunities, it's crucial to lean heavily into your foundational skills and craft. In an ideal scenario, you book the role, and your professionalism and personality will help you create sustainability in your career.

Additionally, this can open up various other pathways to opportunities, allowing you to expand your horizons and thrive in the industry.

If you are willing to accept that the Artisticpreneurship is the way to go, then we absolutely need to focus on what your brand is. Now, this can be a very frustrating process because in order for your brand to be embraced and sustained, you have to believe in what you're marketing. For example, let's say that because you've seen a ton of celebrities drinking soda in commercials, billboards, TV shows, and movies, you are now saying to yourself, 'I'm going to brand myself as a soda drinker,' but you actually don't drink soda.

How long do you really think you will be able to sustain that?

This is why the title of this chapter is 'The Brand Called You,' because you just need to be willing to sit with yourself and ask yourself some tough questions.

What am I willing to do?

How much of my personal life do I want to share?

And most importantly, does what I want to market lend itself in any way to my craft?

If you're anything like me, you're starting to get frustrated, annoyed, and maybe the little voice of self-doubt is starting to get louder, mainly because you are realizing that this entertainment life isn't as entertaining as it's been sold, and you would be correct. But don't worry, we will get you on your unique path and it's much simpler than you think. Let's start with the basics.

Your Brand Framework:

1. **YOUr Core:** What three meaningful words do you want others to associate with you and your character? (For me, those words are: Authentic, Entrepreneurial, Global)
2. **YOUr Content:** Share your journey, your insights, your growth—not just your successes
3. **YOUr Network:** Connect with creators, not just celebrities

YOUr Core: Identifying how you want others to perceive you is crucial, and the most effective way to reach that conclusion is by selecting three key words that you believe best encapsulate who you are in a nutshell. While this task may initially seem daunting, it will significantly contribute to your journey in brand discovery and management. By thoughtfully choosing these words, you will gain invaluable clarity on your personal brand and how you wish to present yourself to the world around you.

This process can greatly enhance your self-awareness and help you communicate your essence more effectively. Furthermore, these chosen words will serve as a guiding light, influencing your actions and decisions, ultimately aligning your behavior with the image you wish to project. Embracing this exercise not only solidifies your identity but also empowers you to navigate social interactions with confidence and purpose. Engaging in this reflective practice allows you to delve deeper into your core values and beliefs, ensuring that the words you select truly resonate with your authentic self.

As you embrace this journey, you may find that these words evolve over time, reflecting your growth and changes in perspective. Ultimately, this awareness fosters stronger connections with others, as you can express who you are with clarity and conviction, making your interactions more meaningful and impactful.

YOUr Content: Authenticity lies at the very heart of what you are offering. To truly embody this essential quality of authenticity, you must be willing to share not only the triumphs but also the challenging lows of your journey. One of the primary reasons reality television surged in popularity is that it provided audiences with a glimpse into the lives of their so-called "celebrities," revealing that they are, in fact, real people who experience tears, heartbreak, and moments of self-doubt just like anyone else.

This genuine connection and relatability resonate deeply with viewers, creating a bond that goes beyond mere entertainment. It is crucial that you strive to encapsulate this raw, honest experience in your content. By showcasing both your struggles and successes, you can craft a narrative that is not only relatable but also engaging, allowing your audience to connect with you on a more profound level. Embrace the full spectrum of your story, as it is this authenticity that will truly captivate and resonate with those who engage with your work.

YOUr Network: One of my favorite sayings in the business world is that "Your Network is Your Net Worth," and another profound statement is, "Show me the five people you spend the most time with, and I'll tell you who you are!"

To genuinely grow and enhance your value proposition, it is essential to surround yourself with individuals who are operating on the same wavelength as you. This process can take considerable time and effort, as you must carefully filter out those who merely talk a good game from those who are genuinely taking action and making significant things happen.

However, building these connections is incredibly important in this business landscape. It doesn't matter how many people you know; if they don't know you or recognize your value, what is the true worth of knowing them?

Investing time in nurturing these relationships and fostering genuine connections will pay off handsomely in the long run, as the right network can open doors to new opportunities, valuable insights, and collaborations that can significantly elevate your success, drive you toward your goals, and create models of sustainability.

I remember being 23, obviously still struggling as an actor, and I had just quit my job at the Olive Garden to move on to greener pastures, doing background (BG)! You might be thinking, 'Didn't he already tell us the background story?' I did; this is a different background story. Anyway, I'm sitting in BG holding (a room where you wait to go on to the set), and this fellow BG walks over to me and introduces himself. For the sake of this book, let's call him Victor (not his name).

Victor sits down next to me and asks, "What do I do?"

I looked at him very strangely, like it was obvious.

"I do BG."

Because for him, he was/is a model; he just does BG to make some extra cash as he is busy building his brand.

What he was really asking was, 'What are you aspiring to do outside of this?'

"Brand?" I chuckled to myself.

"Bro! You're doing BG; how can you even think about a brand? What you need to be thinking about is making this cross in front of the cameras without disturbing the actors that are talking (Yeah, I was bitter)."

He laughed like I was crazy and proceeded to tell me about how important it was to have something you're known for to be at the forefront of people's minds. He even went as far as to say that he had hired a publicist. At this moment, I started to listen and like him because I finally met someone whose delusion was stronger than mine. Talking about a brand, hiring a publicist, all while doing BG is... (That's a full sentence).

So I thought to myself, "What else do I have to do? I'm just sitting here; let me hear what he has to say."

He then proceeded to pull out his notebook and started flipping through these pages that had all of these ideas, quotes that he'd come up with. Little did I know, as I was laughing at his delusion, he didn't see himself as BG; he saw himself as the star and was moving in that direction regardless of his environment.

We started to become close friends; we would go out for tea (that's all we could afford), and he convinced me to start writing down my brand ideas for myself. I'm not going to lie, I felt a little bit violated as I had never had anyone ask me to explain how I wanted to be seen! It took months just fighting with my inner thoughts, and then when I finally did get something on the page, I would look up and realize that my reality was saying something different. But this was all part of 'discovery.

"How could I ever dream of discovering a character on a page when I can't even discover the man who is reading the page?"

These realities made me want to run away from the industry and not toward it. If this is what it would require? Is this something that I even wanted? I just wanted to act! Victor wasn't hearing any of it. Next thing I know, I'm meeting with his publicist.

Everything felt like it was moving so fast. One moment I'm doing BG, and the next I'm talking to a publicist.

Now, since you have been reading this book, I know you're asking, "Why in the world would he get a publicist when he has nothing to publicize?"

If you asked that, then you would be correct!

Now. I'm doing too much, but let me share with you the upside of having a way-too-soon publicist. It taught me that I need to think bigger, I needed to dream larger, and most importantly, I needed to have some type of vision for myself, as well as not being afraid to talk about the features and character traits that make me unique. I wish I had listened at 23, but I wasn't able to as my cup was already full.

Now, I can look back and say, "Well, there was no social media when these conversations were taking place," and that is true, as long as you don't count Myspace or Facebook.

But when Facebook started, it was only for college attendees. But that's the excuse, not the point.

It's going to be incredibly challenging to place yourself in the optimal position for success if you are not willing to fully accept and embrace what makes YOU uniquely YOU.

While it may sound simple in theory, the real test comes when you actually put pen to paper and then follow through with execution. Recognizing and celebrating your individual strengths and quirks is not just beneficial; it is essential, as these unique elements form the very foundation of your personal brand.

When you take the time to truly understand who you are at your core, the path to success becomes much clearer and more attainable. However, this journey often requires significant effort, dedication, and persistence to bring those ideas into tangible reality. It is through this process of self-discovery and commitment that you unlock your full potential and set yourself on a path toward achieving your goals.

The Opulent Denim Rule: Be famous for your work, not for being famous. Authenticity is the new currency.

Chapter 8: From Artist to Artisticpreneur

This might very well be the most important chapter in this entire book, and I truly believe it holds significant value. I know for me personally that this is the chapter that distinctly separates you from the pack and elevates you from simply being good to achieving greatness!

Let's take a moment to pause and genuinely reflect on the situation; this certainly feels like the pot calling the kettle black, doesn't it? Enough with sounding like my grandparents and their nostalgic tales; it's time for a genuine and meaningful conversation about entrepreneurship instead. Do you remember the very first time you encountered the word "entrepreneur"?

I must admit, I honestly can't recall that specific moment, but what truly stands out to me is that I certainly didn't hear that term during my formative years. In fact, I never came across it in my school curriculum at all, and even in my acting classes or through my first agents and manager, it was never a topic of discussion or consideration. Back in those days, I held the belief that entrepreneurship was something reserved exclusively for the wealthy elite, as if it were merely a sophisticated term to signify that someone was affluent and privileged! I had no idea that it could actually represent a way of life or a unique lifestyle that anyone, regardless of their background, could aspire to pursue and achieve.

This realization has completely transformed my perspective, and once I discovered it, it felt like a drug; I craved a constant fix! The funny thing is, I had no clue if there were books dedicated to teaching how to become an entrepreneur. I would wander into bookstores, seeing shelves filled with real estate books, stock market books, and technology books, all of which seemed incredibly dense and intimidating. If you were anything like me, you might have wondered how any of these concepts could possibly become achievable when you have no money to invest or start with.

The challenges felt insurmountable, and the path ahead appeared so unclear.

What could I possibly do in this situation?

The only thing that seemed to make any sense at all was to pick up a book and immerse myself in reading. Yes, I fell asleep multiple times while attempting to read the same sentences over and over again, feeling utterly frustrated. Yes, I had absolutely no idea what any of these fancy business terms actually meant or how they applied to my life. But I had to hold on to the belief that, much like going to the gym, the initial experience feels like pure hell.

However, after enduring that initial struggle for a while, it starts to get easier and easier.

Eventually, you begin to see tangible progress and understand concepts that once seemed completely foreign and out of reach. I will admit that as I was reading, it became more like fantasy reading, an opportunity to escape into some wealthy individual's life, sitting in the boardroom discussing how to take over the competing company. It had never registered to me that this was something that I could achieve.

Then one day, I stumbled upon this intriguing purple book that caught my eye. It was noticeably smaller in page size compared to the other books lining the shelves, and it bore the title "Rich Dad Poor Dad" by Robert Kiyosaki. I won't lie; it was the title itself that first drew me in. This was the first occasion when I encountered a business book that recognized the existence of a class beyond just the wealthy elite. If you haven't had the chance to read it yet, I would highly recommend giving it a try.

Essentially, Robert Kiyosaki shares the stark contrasts between his biological father, whom he refers to as his poor dad, and his mentor, known as his rich dad. The poor dad taught him the traditional route of completing school and securing a job, while the rich dad contended that formal education often lacks the real-life skills necessary for true success. He warned that if you rely solely on your schooling, you might very well end up struggling financially.

You can imagine how all of this would be quite jarring for someone like me, who left school at the age of 15. I felt a surge of hope, as if the rich dad was implying that my unconventional education might actually provide me with a unique advantage in the world of entrepreneurship. Whether that notion was accurate or not became less significant; when you find yourself grappling with financial hardships, you're always on the lookout for something to believe in, and I discovered that spark of inspiration within his words. He explored how poor, middle-class, and wealthy individuals allocate their money and the types of investments they prioritize. He then emphasized that the truly wealthy consistently focus on investing in real estate as a pathway to achieving financial freedom and security. This perspective shifted my understanding of wealth and opportunity in profound ways.

Now I'm thinking, "imagine if I booked a couple of commercials, TV shows, or movies." I could take that money and invest it in a property and make money off it (I know, easier said than done). Well, then I should just do that!

Finally, there was something else that I could focus on, another goal if you will. Some would say it's a distraction, as if all distractions are bad. I kept saying all I have to do is book one job, and I am going to immediately implement what Robert said. The one common theme I noticed in all of the business books was don't live beyond your means.

Quite simply, don't spend more than you're bringing in. It seems so basic, but it was something that was profound; he might as well have been walking on water.

Finally, I got a call and I have been booked to be a background actor in this Gatorade commercial. The funny thing is that now that I have started reading these business books, I was looking at money differently. So, I happily went, and it was a long, long shoot day.

Nonetheless, I felt brand new sitting in the corner with my business books, of course now trying to educate those around me on the things I had only just learned the night before. Lol, no one was interested, if you're wondering. We wrapped the shoot, and I headed back to my uncle's house where he had this massive second living room upstairs, and I was sleeping on a mattress in the corner. I was so happy I was reading, had a comfortable place to sleep, and I had just booked a commercial. Well, I had just done background work for a commercial; I had about \$20 or so in my account, but with no other bills (not true, I just decided not to pay them). It felt like things were starting to change.

Five weeks later, I get a phone call from my former roommate, "Yo, you got this letter and it's super thick."

I quickly said, "Just throw it away; I'm sure it's a bill collector."

He was like, "Nah, it says entertainment on the letterhead. Should I open it?"

You can guess my response: "Hell yeah!!"

He does and then proceeds to tell me that I have made the principal edit and I am on camera for longer than five seconds, which means that I can no longer be considered BG but a principal actor. My heart sank. They had attached a new 'Principal Contract' to the letter for me to sign and return so that they could send me new payments. Ladies and gentlemen, we have turned the corner; I am now a 'principal actor' with money incoming, and I am reading business books. What could get in my way?

There I am, standing in the kitchen of my uncle's house, and my phone rings.

It's my former roommate. "Yo! You got some mail here that looks like some checks!"

I was so excited that I said, "Can you drive them down to me because I don't have gas money to get up there?"

He laughed, and I knew what that meant...I was on my own. So I borrowed some money from my uncle and drove up to the old apartment with a new lease on life. I practically ran through the door, grabbed the mail, and ripped them open. It was as if I had been in the desert for months and then water showed up. I opened envelope after envelope and saw checks for \$3,000 and \$7,000. I was speechless. The total amount was a little over \$15,000! After years, finally a little breathing room.

"This money will be used to buy more business books and invest in my craft," I said!

Eight months later I was completely broke! Yup, you heard it. No money... What happened? I'm glad you asked. I blew it! I decided to go and live the life that I felt I was missing the past couple of years while I was struggling... and baby boy didn't need to struggle anymore.

I wanted to go out and drink, take different women out on dates; eventually, I made one my girlfriend, and instead of us taking it slow, I was like, "Girl, we're together all the time, so why don't we just move in together?"

She agreed. Now I've gone from paying a little rent to my uncle of about \$400 a month to a one-bedroom apartment in North Hollywood at \$1,250 a month...Yeah, if you do the math, you will quickly see that \$15k could go in the blink of an eye if the only bill you had was rent. Now I'm adding a girlfriend, eating out, paying for drinks with my friends, and occasionally reading a business book, but what's the point? Business books were for the poor.

Reality really struck when I was standing in a pet shop trying to buy some dog food for \$10 and my card kept getting declined. I knew it was a mistake; I had spent some money, but I did have at least \$10. The cashier assured me it was probably the machine. I stepped outside and looked at my bank account, and I saw that I was negative \$600. I now owed the bank money for having had money. I was more broke now than before I even booked the national commercial; everything had unraveled.

It was in that moment that I realized I had done everything but change my mindset!

I was still operating on a scarcity mindset. I was beginning to get the tools, but I didn't understand how or when to use them, and so, just like that, it was all gone.

The great thing about what had happened was that I had started reading much more frequently, and even though I was financially poor, mentally I felt extremely wealthy. That was until I was talking to my then ex on the phone, trying to see if we could potentially get back together.

She now lived in another state, and I had said, 'I will come and see you.' She said the words I would never forget.

She looked at the phone—at the time it was Skype—chuckled to herself, and said, 'How are you going to come see me? You're poor!'

Up until that point in my life, I had heard a lot of things that stung, but this one felt like a death blow, mainly because it was from someone I once loved and whom I thought loved me. It was so easy for the words to come out of their mouths; it was almost like they rehearsed it every day. In that moment, I decided that those could never be words that anyone utters to me again!

Do you have a similar experience?

I know, I know, you're probably thinking, "When do we talk about being an entrepreneur?"

Well, the answer is quite simple: "That's what we have been discussing throughout this entire chapter!"

In the past, I used to believe that an entrepreneur only experienced positive outcomes. I thought they invested their money, and then it multiplied effortlessly, like magic, leading to more money and even more friends. I imagined that every time you bought a property, it would automatically generate profit, and then you would just move on to the next big opportunity without any hiccups. However, it's quite rare to hear people discussing the challenges and setbacks they faced along the way.

The truth is, most advertising is designed to sell you hope and optimism, glossing over the struggles. I'm not here to sell you a dream; instead, I want to uplift you and empower you to decide for yourself what kind of artist you aspire to be.

The journey of an artist, much like that of an entrepreneur, is filled with numerous ups and downs, trials and tribulations. There will be moments when it feels like the world is your oyster, and other times when you feel as if you've been struck with food poisoning. Embracing both the triumphs and the challenges is what truly shapes your path.

How long can you delay gratification?

This is the true test of an artist and entrepreneur. If you can hold off on immediate rewards for just one more day and fill that day with more opportunities, you will find even more chances presented to you tomorrow. This is when everything started to click for me; it became clear that I needed to build an ecosystem around what I was doing.

I began to wonder, is it possible to recession-proof my career? Imagine being an artist who books multiple gigs, and instead of taking that money and spending it on short-term comforts, you invest it in an income-generating property.

This could be a duplex, a two-bedroom, three-bedroom, or even four-bedroom apartment, or perhaps simply purchasing a bachelor pad and renting it out. By doing this, you create a steady stream of income every month, regardless of whether you are booking gigs. This approach would naturally alleviate some of the pressure associated with auditioning, as you would no longer need the money just to keep the lights on. Instead, you could focus purely on your craft, immerse yourself in the text, and take creative risks. This shift in mindset would allow you to be in a much more relaxed state, ultimately enhancing your performance and artistic expression.

The more income you are able to generate, the more you're able to focus on your craft. Your foundation is now becoming reinforced. You are creating guardrails. I know this doesn't happen overnight because it took me a decade from the time I picked up my first investment book to purchasing my first investment property.

So I don't want you to think that if you just decide that's what you are going to do, it will just happen. Now, maybe it will for you, and undoubtedly, if you create solid connections, brand and market yourself well, and delay gratification, that timeline could become much shorter.

One of the many added bonuses of investing is that you have the opportunity to put your money into things that genuinely excite you, provided you have conducted thorough research and development to determine how you can achieve a strong return on investment.

My suggestion is to focus on areas that you actively engage with, use frequently, or discuss often in your daily life. It's also beneficial to surround yourself with business-minded individuals who inspire and challenge you. Reading insightful books like this one, as well as classics such as Rich Dad Poor Dad, can provide valuable perspectives.

Additionally, there are countless podcasts available that delve into various investment strategies and personal development topics. Personally, I've reached a point in my life where I prefer listening to podcasts while I work out instead of music. I find that immersing myself in conversations filled with positivity and abundant knowledge is far more enriching and motivating.

My Entrepreneurial Journey:

Real Estate(Apartments/Land): Because actors need stable income between jobs & people always need a roof.

Wine Company(TAU Wines): Because networking happens over drinks

Cigar Brand Investment(Bongani): Because luxury markets understand branding and the best conversations happen over a cigar

Luxury Leather Goods(JokaJok): Because quality craftsmanship tells a story

Speaking Career: Because my experiences have value beyond entertainment

When I was 23, I never would have imagined that any of these incredible things could be possible. Even as I write this now, it still feels surreal to me, as if I am living in a dream. However, what truly excites me even more is the opportunity to share this information with you.

Perhaps you find yourself in a situation that mirrors exactly where I was at 23, or maybe you are in an even better position, giving you a head start to fully explore and take advantage of all the amazing possibilities that lie ahead.

It's important to emphasize, though, that I never suggested abandoning your foundation, which is your artistry. This foundation is absolutely crucial, as it not only serves to enhance your experience but also makes the art even more enjoyable for both you and those who encounter it.

Think of it like playing Monopoly, and owning all of the properties; when you roll the dice, do you really care what number ends up on the dice? Exactly! This is being an Artisticpreneur.

Now, imagine the opposite—you own no properties, and someone else owns all of them. Think of the way you would be holding the dice, even blowing on them before you throw them for good luck, closing your eyes and feeling your stomach in knots. This is what it's like to be just an artist walking into an audition room; everything starts to feel like a gamble, and you don't know what you don't know. Knowledge is power.

Chapter 9: The Knowledge Advantage

I've had the privilege of teaching masterclasses across a diverse range of locations, from Johannesburg to Jamaica. I've been a speaker at the prestigious US-Africa Business Summit, Forbes 30 under 30. Additionally, I've participated in World Bank panels that focus on the vital aspects of the creative economy, as well as teaching Governments how the business of entertainment makes money and how it can positively impact GDP and create thousands of jobs

Thinking back, I realize that I did not have my first significant speaking opportunity until I moved to Africa. It's quite striking to reflect on the years I spent living in Hollywood, working on popular projects like Yellowstone, among many others, yet during that time, I was never once invited to speak anywhere. I don't share this from a place of bitterness; rather, I express this from a place of deep reflection and personal growth. It serves as a reminder that success can come from the most unexpected places.

I want to emphasize that if you don't live in the United States, you should feel even more encouraged. You do not have to be in Los Angeles or any major city to achieve remarkable results and make your voice heard in meaningful ways. Your location does not define your ability to succeed or limit your potential; it's your passion, dedication, and willingness to share your insights that truly matter.

I remember the very first time I taught a master class in the beautiful country of Botswana. I was incredibly excited to share the wealth of knowledge I had absorbed during my time in Los Angeles. I had a strong feeling that this class was going to be a huge success, and I envisioned long lines wrapped around the building, eagerly waiting to get in. After all, I was on the number one show in the world, which added to my confidence. I believe I spent about three and a half weeks marketing this class, pouring my energy into it.

However, what I failed to realize, because I was so eager to get started without conducting any research or development, was that the way you market something in Botswana is not at all the same as how you would market it in Los Angeles. So when the day finally arrived, I was shocked to see that I had fewer than 40 people in attendance for the class. I was completely confused and disheartened, and just like that, all of the self-doubt I had worked so hard to push aside came rushing back in, leaving me questioning my abilities and my approach.

The reality was that I didn't truly understand the diverse cultures and perspectives of various parts of the world. Instead of approaching the situation with an open global mindset, I was entering with a narrow Hollywood mindset, which can be seen as myopic and closed-minded. This limited viewpoint greatly prevented me from fully appreciating the richness and complexity of different societies and the unique experiences that shape them. It was clear that without a broader perspective, I was missing out on the valuable insights and lessons that come from engaging with a wide array of cultural backgrounds.

After this incredibly humbling experience, I decided to fully immerse myself in research and development, and to truly engage in what I do best: connecting with people. I began visiting various restaurants and sitting at bar tops, asking the workers about the real state of the entertainment landscape in the country. Rather than arriving with my cup already full of preconceived notions, I realized that I needed to be open to receiving new insights and perspectives.

Now, I am not only learning how to effectively grow my brand, but I am also discovering how to create real value within the country itself. This has become a core principle that I have taken all around the world. Using this principle, the next time I conducted a Masterclass in Botswana, we had over 1,600 artists in attendance! This is how, "Go Opulent, Go Global!", was born.

Here's what I've learned from teaching thousands of artists globally:

Discover the common thread that unites every individual across diverse backgrounds: the arts serve as an incredibly powerful force that transcends all barriers, including those of race, religion, and financial status.

If the ultimate goal truly revolves around genuine expansion and growth in both personal and communal spheres, then you, as an individual, must wholeheartedly embrace and seize the invaluable opportunity to broaden your horizons and explore new perspectives.

Engaging with the arts can open numerous doors to deeper understanding and meaningful connection, ultimately enriching not only your life but also the lives of those around you, fostering a more harmonious and empathetic community. Through this engagement, you can contribute to a shared experience that celebrates our collective humanity.

This is not to say that you should forget that your primary goal is to run and effectively scale a successful business, with that business being your unique brand. The most effective way to achieve this objective is by consistently adding significant value and solving a real problem for your creative audience. You should utilize the same foundational principles that you would apply when you walk into an audition room. In that setting, preparation, attention to detail, and a deep understanding of your audience are absolutely key to making a lasting impression.

This is where knowledge gives you the advantage over others.

As the years have passed and my life has firmly settled here in Africa, I have come to realize that, at my very core, I have a deep love for knowledge and a genuine passion for sharing that knowledge in order to empower and uplift others. I call this The **Global Opulent Toolkit**.

I've discovered that you can truly empower people while also making a profit, creating a situation that benefits everyone involved. It becomes a complete 360-degree win for all parties. This isn't one of those 'oh, come to Africa and save people' lines; this is the fact that proves if you continue to expand your horizons, wherever you find yourself in the world, and you leave your cup with enough room to be poured into, you'll always have more to pour into others, and your bank account will also receive some pouring.

What you will begin to notice is that the same principles needed to be a successful artist are the same principles needed to be an entrepreneur. The more you know, the more you grow.

The Global Opulent Toolkit:

1. **Cultural Intelligence:** Understanding not just different cultures, but how stories travel across cultures
2. **Financial Literacy:** Understanding exchange rates, international taxes, global banking
3. **Digital Fluency:** Understanding how to build presence across continents
4. **Cultural Intelligence:** There is a great saying, "Traveling makes a man wise."

When I heard this for the first time, it didn't resonate with me in the same way that it does now.

Why?

Well, because I hadn't traveled beyond different states. Even though that was a nice experience, there is something about seeing the same flag everywhere I went that didn't feel big or global. So, once I finally made a little money, the only thing I wanted to do was travel.

The Covid years changed the world in a major way, and for me, they made me feel like I had not experienced enough of life. After all, I am an actor, and part of my job is the ability to draw from lived experiences and have interesting stories and insights.

One of my main takeaways after having traveled to over 15 countries in the past several years is that spending time with locals, listening more than talking, and asking questions to learn rather than to compare are some of the most valuable tools not only for you as an artist but also as an entrepreneur.

Learning how people do business, for example, the way you do business in Namibia is not the same way you would do it in India. So, if your goal is to go global with your brand, your brand is you, and thus, you must also go global.

Financial Literacy:

This is a demon that I still fight with daily! If you don't have financial literacy, then all of the knowledge and information you have acquired in this book will be close to useless!

And if you are anything like me, you did not come from an entrepreneurial family, so this might be something that you have to be even more intentional about. But if we are going global, this financial literacy will be the tool that truly sets you apart.

As you travel, you will see that every country has a different exchange rate (the rate at which one currency can be exchanged for another; it's essentially the "price" of a currency). For example, \$1 is 18 Rands (ZAR) in South Africa. This means you can get a lot more bang for your buck in South Africa using US dollars. This means I can stay longer in the country, experience finer hotels, dining experiences, and potentially even financially invest in businesses that I may not have been able to invest in because of the price of entry in the country that I am residing in.

So if and when you decide to go global and start a business in a different country, or even invest in one, you need to understand the international tax implications as well. Now, do you need to be an expert? No! But you can and should consult with one.

Remember, we are no longer thinking about, "I'm just trying to book an audition."

We have been there, done that, and are looking at the next step. So, when you're reading this, don't allow yourself to recoil in negativity. Just like the exchange rate, each country has a different tax code.

So when you find the country that you enjoy spending time in, also make sure it's a country that you enjoy paying some taxes in as well, because you may find that the people and products of the country are great, but the government is going to take too much of your hard-earned capital. Then you will have to make a business decision. (More on this in my next book **Opulent Business**).

I remember that when I got to Botswana, I brought with me around \$10,000 in cash because I was unsure how much anything cost and if there were any banks I could use with a US card. Luckily, after a year of being in the country, I was brave enough to stick my card in the ATM machine, and to my surprise, money came out (of course it would; it's Visa/Mastercard).

However, it charged me about a 3% exchange rate on the money I was taking out. If you are just in a country to travel, then it's best to accept the exchange fee and chalk it up to the price of traveling. But if you want to actually do business in the country, it's best to open a local bank account. This doesn't happen overnight, and there is paperwork and registration that is required, but depending on the country, we at **Opulent Entertainment Group** can help with that. It's frustrating at the start, but it provides a massive benefit in the long run. It also helps diversify your finances away from just one country, granting you even more flexibility.

Digital Fluency:

How can you effectively take the valuable knowledge and wisdom you've accumulated over the years, along with the strong foundation of your craft, and apply it in meaningful ways, regardless of the direction your journey takes?

This process may require considerable time and patience, as you, an artistic entrepreneur, will continually find yourself in a dynamic state of learning, evolving, and growing. However, it is crucial to recognize that there are essential foundational principles that you should always be able to rely on and draw from as you navigate the ever-changing landscape filled with opportunities and challenges. Embracing and internalizing these principles will not only empower you to adapt and thrive in various situations but will also ensure that your skills and insights remain relevant, impactful, and resonant throughout your artistic journey, allowing you to connect deeply with your audience and make a lasting difference in your field.

Think of Digital Fluency as your defense, and to use a sports analogy, your defense always travels even when the offense isn't doing its part, so your ability to take what you have learned and create and leverage it in different environments will ultimately be the difference between you sitting at home or sitting in a business meeting.

The Forbes 30 Under 30 Insight:

The most successful young creators aren't just talented—they're Globally aware. They understand:

Which content works on TikTok vs. YouTube and in which countries

How to monetize across borders

How to build Global communities, not just audiences

It wasn't until I was sitting on a panel at Forbes that I looked around and quickly realized, "Damn, do I even know anything?"

I loved it because I was in a room full of youthful creators who have dedicated all of their time to solving problems and adding value to their countries and communities. Is that not what we do as artists? Another important highlight was that I actually met one of my future business partners, Dr. Brett, at the Forbes event being held in Botswana. Yes, you read that correctly—not LA, NY, or London, but Botswana! We exchanged ideas and later met for dinner in South Africa, where we decided to go into business together.

Now, this all goes back to my earlier point in this book: I am thousands of miles away from the US, and he is a medical doctor. If it weren't for my traveling and constantly trying to grow and build, we would have never met.

This is one of the reasons why I am so passionate about us as artists attending more events outside of just film festivals. Those are great, but you also need to build relationships with people outside of the entertainment space if you are really going to be an entrepreneur.

Attending these events and building connections is how I learned what is happening in different countries, what content the local audience has an appetite for, and where I should go if I want to connect with more like-minded individuals. This is something that cannot be achieved by just sitting at home. Part of the knowledge game is connection and collaboration.

So, imagine you are in a new country and you connect with some local artists who are doing well; you can offer to collaborate with them on TikTok or a podcast on YouTube. This offers a tremendous value proposition as it allows you to plug into their country's community and vice versa, thus helping you build a global audience.

Relationships are essential for both personal and professional growth, but actively enhancing those relationships is what truly ensures their longevity over time. Often, this enhancement requires stepping far beyond your usual comfort zone to cultivate and strengthen these vital connections.

That's why attending entrepreneurial summits is crucial for your ongoing development and success. Even if you're not one of the speakers on a panel, the attendees around you are incredibly important; everyone present shares a common purpose and goal. They believe they have valuable insights and contributions to offer, are eager to tackle challenges, seek financial success, and are committed to forging enduring partnerships that can lead to mutual growth and achievement, giving you valuable knowledge to help you scale into the future.

The World Bank Revelation:

The creative industries are the fastest-growing sector in emerging economies.

When I spoke about this, I realized: We're not just entertainers. We're economic development agents.

The global intellectual property (IP) industry is an astounding \$2.4 trillion industry! I understand that this figure may seem unfathomable, even as I type this out, but its significance for your ability to create, monetize, and scale is incredibly profound, regardless of the country you are in or the people who surrounded you. Once you shift your perspective and stop viewing yourself merely as an "artist," I genuinely believe that you will begin to see yourself as a powerful force, fully capable of transforming your dreams into reality. Provided, you are willing to put in the hard work that is required!

Embracing this mindset can open up a vast world of opportunities and possibilities that you may not have previously considered. This does require you to start familiarizing yourself with some business concepts and terminology that may not rival the excitement of your favorite fantasy novel. However, if you can engage with this new information and get it right, you will find that you have the power to make your reality align with your deepest aspirations, turning your dreams into an achievable fantasy.

Your Opulent Knowledge Checklist:

Understand basic contract law in your country

Study successful artists from 3 different countries

Follow global entertainment news (not just Hollywood)

Teach what you know (teaching solidifies learning)

Understanding basic contract law in your country:

It is not just important; it is absolutely crucial for artists who wish to protect their careers and interests. Many artists have faced significant challenges and had their entire careers turned upside down simply because they didn't know what questions to ask when it came time to review a contract. It's vital to remember that hiring an attorney does not exempt you from the responsibility of being able to ask specific, informed questions that are tailored to your unique wants and needs as an artist.

The more knowledgeable you become in this area, the less likely you are to be taken advantage of by individuals or organizations that may not have your best interests at heart. It is essential to empower yourself with information and a thorough understanding of contract law, enabling you to navigate your professional relationships with confidence and clarity. By doing so, you will be better equipped to make decisions that align with your artistic vision and career goals.

Study successful artists from three different countries:

This will greatly enhance your ability to break into various markets around the globe. By closely examining these accomplished artists, you will not only uncover which agents represent them but also identify the casting directors involved in the productions they are associated with. Engaging in this in-depth research and development underscores the crucial importance of thorough investigation and development, which is essential for achieving your long-term success in the industry.

This approach not only broadens your understanding of diverse artistic expressions but also equips you with vital connections that can propel your career forward as you look to scale beyond your borders.

Stay updated with Global entertainment news:

If you find yourself scrolling through social media for hours at a time (and let's be honest, we all do it), then you are in an excellent position to stay informed about global events. The key difference here is that this knowledge can significantly benefit your business.

Make it a priority to keep your ear to the ground regarding what is happening around the world, as this awareness will also aid you in learning how to effectively track and identify trends that could impact your industry.

If you do have an agent or manager, this will help you assist them in potentially getting you into rooms that they didn't even know existed.

Don't forget you are the founder and CEO of your company; no one should work harder than you to build the business.

Teach what you know:

I have come to realize that I retain information much more effectively when I actively share it with others. It's essential to recognize that the only person you are truly competing against is yourself and your own growth. Therefore, sharing what you know, even though it may make you feel vulnerable, actually enhances your overall value in the process.

This vulnerability, rather than being perceived as a weakness, can transform into a significant asset that contributes to your personal development. It allows you not only to grow personally and deepen your understanding of the subject matter but also to monetize that value in meaningful and impactful ways that benefit both you and those you teach.

By embracing this approach, you create a dynamic learning environment that fosters collaboration and inspires others to share their knowledge as well, creating a 360-degree win.

With so much information and numerous action points, it can feel daunting to put everything into context. However, I would much rather have you be overwhelmed with useful information and actionable steps than to find yourself stuck and feeling discouraged.

Lets go from **Lost to Legacy.**

Chapter 10: Building Your Opulent Legacy

Ten years ago, I was another actor trying to make it. Today, I'm building something that will outlive me.

Did I ever think that I could achieve half of the things that I am doing now, then?

Absolutely, I never had a dreaming problem; I had a mindset and execution problem.

Ask anyone who knows me, and they will tell you I might be the least patient person on the globe. I want everything to happen as quickly as I think of it, and that has been a hard pill to swallow as this artistic life takes time.

One of the key things that has significantly helped me was when I began to contemplate the concept of legacy. During this period, I immersed myself in reading incredible biographies of inventors, explorers, entertainers, and tech giants.

It became clear to me that they all shared multiple common traits. They dared to dream beyond the boundaries of their current reality, they experienced failures early and often, and they never permitted the lack of vision from those around them to obscure the strong vision they held for themselves. This realization has profoundly influenced my own aspirations and approach to life, and I hope it will influence you on your road to your own unique legacy.

We are not finished just yet; we still have one crucial mission ahead of us. This mission is the Roadmap. We cannot effectively chart our course without first identifying the key checkpoints we need to reach along the way. In this chapter, we will provide a comprehensive roadmap, or timeline if you prefer, that outlines the essential action items. By diligently following the steps laid out in this book, you will set yourself on a strong and promising path toward conquering an audition and achieving lasting success.

Year 1-3: The Foundation

Master your craft locally

Build your digital presence

Create your first income stream outside acting

Your foundation is undoubtedly the most crucial part of establishing your lasting legacy. You simply cannot scale your efforts effectively if you have not first dedicated the necessary time to master your craft. This mastery is not something that can be achieved overnight, so it is vital that you do not feel rushed in this area of your development. Take your time and focus on getting it right, as this process is essential not only for your growth but also for your overall journey as an artist. You absolutely must get this right, as your entire brand and future success are hinged on your ability and growth in this creative field.

Nurture your skills and allow yourself the space to evolve without the pressure of immediate results. Keep in mind that we are living in a global and digital world, so you should actively document your journey as you progress.

Remember, don't get discouraged when you feel like no one is paying attention; this is all about creating a presence. You are leaving behind breadcrumbs along the way, ensuring that when people finally start to come to your social media pages, you have a wealth of content and experiences to offer them. Embrace the journey and trust the process, as it will ultimately serve you well in the long run.

On your journey, it is essential to consistently lean into your unique strengths. Take the time to explore a variety of hobbies and interests, read a diverse range of books across different genres, and discover a seamless and effective way to leverage these strengths to create opportunities for generating income and achieving your financial goals. This alleviates the pressure of just trying to book a role and allows you to go into every audition fully locked in and engaged, not "needing it" to keep your lights on.

Year 4-7: The Expansion

Go global with your auditions

Build a team (agent, manager, maybe lawyer)

Start your first business

Once you feel confident that you have established a solid foundation and have dedicated time to refining your value proposition, it is the perfect moment to begin making significant power moves. Now is the ideal time to actively pursue opportunities that lie beyond your current location, as well as to focus on assembling a skilled team around you to ensure that you are moving accurately and consistently staying on brand. If you have already secured a few projects and have been diligently building your social media presence, then you are in an excellent position to start reaching out to agents. This is a crucial step in expanding your reach and enhancing your professional network, which can lead to even more exciting opportunities in the future.

Once you are making some money, the first official business that you should register is YOU! You are a business, and now you need the team around you to build it effectively.

It is during this transformative period that I believe most artists learn the most about themselves, as they transition from being solely accountable to themselves to managing a team of individuals who rely on their guidance and direction. This shift also introduces the complexities of global audition pressures, where different time zones can create significant challenges for scheduling.

Additionally, artists may find themselves facing unexpected costs, such as having to pay for last-minute airfare in order to attend important meetings or auditions, further complicating their journey.

However, you will be thankful that you spent so much time on your foundational process because if you have some revenue being generated in your business, it allows you a buffer when last-minute costs arise. You also must ensure that you have a clear vision of your expansion, as your team needs to know how they should be representing you. Not being able to communicate that effectively will not only slow your expansion down, but it may even lead to the termination of the business relationship. So don't try to expand before you know you're ready.

I have emphasized this repeatedly throughout this book (as I have to take my own advice), but it bears repeating: no one can or will work harder on your business than you. Therefore, your primary focus must be on the business of you! This is a crucial moment where you should shift your perspective from merely seeing yourself as an artist to recognizing that you are now a small business poised for growth and expansion.

During this pivotal checkpoint, it is essential to actively participate in global events, build meaningful relationships, and continue to promote your unique talents and skills. Additionally, leverage your craft strategically to gain access to larger and more prestigious opportunities that can elevate your career.

Year 8-10: The Legacy

Mentor other artists

Invest in creative infrastructure in your community

Build something that creates opportunities for others

Congratulations, you made it! You have conquered the expansion, and now it's time to stabilize and implement systems that promote sustainability. This is your moment to build a bridge and extend a helping hand to others. Remember, at the beginning of this book, you were stuck and frustrated, and now you find yourself in a position to assist others who are experiencing similar feelings. The best way to ensure that you leave a lasting legacy is to positively impact as many people as you can throughout your journey.

While money may come and go, the way you make people feel will create an impact that extends far beyond your financial contributions or even your time on this earth. Embrace this opportunity to inspire and uplift others, for that is where true fulfillment lies.

Mentoring the artists of today and tomorrow is not just the right thing to do; it is an essential aspect of nurturing creativity and innovation. Engaging with young talent keeps you feeling youthful and invigorated while also serving as a safeguard against becoming disillusioned. In the ever-changing landscape of this artistic journey, filled with numerous highs and lows, it is all too easy to emerge feeling worn out and entrenched in a singular way of thinking.

However, surrounding yourself with a generation eager to learn, tackle challenges, and strive to become the best versions of themselves can transform your own experience into something truly remarkable. This relationship might even turn out to be the most memorable part of your entire journey. The knowledge and insights you possess are incredibly valuable, and they deserve not only to be shared but also to be appreciated and actively implemented.

Now that we have entered the mentoring phase, it's time to genuinely invest and put our money where our mouth is. The most significant action you can take during this crucial legacy phase is to build or update the infrastructure that the next generation of artists and creatives will learn, grow, and flourish in. Take a moment to reflect deeply and ask yourself how many buildings, institutions, and existing businesses in your country are specifically dedicated to nurturing and supporting up-and-coming artists and creative minds.

It's absolutely essential to create vibrant spaces that not only foster their unique talents but also provide them with the vital resources and opportunities they need to thrive and succeed in their chosen fields. If you happen to be stuck and don't know what you would invest in, just think back to when you were a young, starving artist and what you wished existed to make your journey easier.

In one of my recent social media posts, someone asked me, "How do I define success now compared to when I first started?"

In the beginning, my focus was primarily on myself—what I wanted and how many people could see me and acknowledge my achievements. It was a very self-centered perspective. However, my view of success has evolved significantly over time. Now, it's all about how many people I can truly impact in a positive way. One of the most effective ways to do this is by creating and investing in systems that generate meaningful employment opportunities for others. Teach others how to invest and create independence.

This shift in focus not only enriches my life but also helps to uplift those around me. When it stops being about just feeding yourself and your family, the world opens up, and I believe that is where true meaning comes in. The "Me" phase is needed, but remember, it is just a phase.

The Final Truth:

The most Opulent thing you can build isn't a mansion or a car collection. It's a career, on your own terms.

It's waking up knowing you can **create from anywhere, provide value globally, and build a life that reflects your deepest values.**

I've stood on red carpets, but the greater thrill has been standing in rooms in Kenya or Trinidad, looking at young artists and saying: "You can do this from right here. Your accent isn't a barrier—it's your signature. Your location isn't a limitation—it's your unique perspective."

Hollywood is an idea. And today, that idea belongs to anyone brave enough to claim it!

Your Next Step:

This isn't the end—it's YOUR BEGINNING.

Tomorrow, do one thing differently:

Find a local filmmaker and collaborate.

Set up your professional self-tape space.

Research one agent in a country you don't live in.

Brainstorm one business idea related to your art.

Believe that your version of "Opulent" is possible.

The Opulent Mindset:

Opulent doesn't mean flashy. It means substantial, valuable, enduring. The world is waiting for your story. Tell it from where you are. Build something Opulent. Build something lasting.

Remember, "Go Opulent, Go Global!"

See you on Global screens,

Denim Richards

THE OPULENT ARTIST "Taking The Starving out of Starving artist."

In "The Opulent Artist," discover how to transform your creative passion into a thriving entertainment career, regardless of your location. This guide, infused with real-world insights and veteran experiences, empowers you to leverage your unique perspective and connections to break free from the starving artist stereotype. Embrace actionable strategies to build your brand, expand your network, and cultivate a sustainable path to success in the ever-evolving entertainment industry.